Blanding Downtown Plan

PREPARED BY: BikeUtah

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BLANDING CITY

Acknowledgments

Thank you to stakeholders and the public for providing feedback through surveys, interviews, and community workshops throughout this planning process.

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Table of Contents

Chapter 1: Introduction 04

How To Use This Plan 05
Blanding City 06
Community Engagement 10
Qualities of a Great Downtown 15

Chapter 2: Transportation 18

Existing Conditions 19
US-191 23
Local Roads 25
Parking 27
Active Transportation 30
Transportation Recommendations 32

Chapter 3: Land Use and Building Design 33

Existing Conditions 34
Downtown District Zoning Code 38
Downtown District Design Guidelines 40
Development Scenarios 41

Chapter 4: Wayfinding and Street Amenities 47

Standard Streetscape Layout 48
Streetscape Quality 49
Street Amenities Inventory 55
Street Amenity Recommendations 65
Wayfinding 66

Chapter 5: Branding and Marketing 68

Regional Context 69
What is Blanding's Brand? 70
Priority Audiences 71
Marketing Tools and Strategies 72
Partnerships 73
Inspiration from Utah Communities 74
Branding and Marketing Recommendations 77

Chapter 6: Implementation Plan 78

Next Steps 79
Implementation Timeline 80
Business Development Strategies 82
Additional Resources 83
Funding Strategies 84

Appendix A: Downtown District Zoning Code 86

Appendix B: Downtown District Design Guidelines 92

CHAPTER

01 Introduction

How To Use This Plan

Purpose

This plan provides Blanding City with a strategic guide for improving its downtown. These recommendations are designed to enhance walkability, support local businesses, attract visitors, and improve quality of life for residents.

City leaders and staff should use this plan to understand existing conditions and opportunities, support more walkable zoning standards, guide downtown investments, and prioritize implementation strategies.

Downtown Blanding

Objectives

Transportation - Calm traffic on US-191, improve local street design, address parking needs, and enhance active transportation infrastructure like sidewalks and pedestrian crossings.

Land Use and Building Design - Revitalize abandoned buildings, support infill development, allow mixed use, and ensure new buildings contribute to a walkable, attractive downtown.

Wayfinding and Street Amenities - Develop a wayfinding system to highlight key downtown destinations. Enhance the walking experience with trees, benches, lighting, trash cans, signs, and other amenities.

Branding and Marketing - Establish a clear and consistent identity for downtown Blanding that celebrates the town's unique character and attracts visitors.

Scope

This plan provides an existing conditions analysis and recommendations for each of the four planning objectives, shown above, organized into four separate chapters

Planning Process

This plan was developed through close collaboration with Blanding City staff, community members, and local stakeholders.

- **On-site Assessments** - May 14-15
- **Community Workshop** - May 15
- **Online Survey** - June 1-30
- **Plan Development** - June-September
- **Existing Conditions Presentations** - 8/26 and 9/11
- **Adoption Presentations** -

Blanding City

Blanding is a small community in Southwestern Utah. With a population around 3,300 people, Blanding is the most populated city in San Juan County and serves as a gateway to the Four Corners region.

- 3,300 people
- 1,096 households
- 13.2 square miles including significant undeveloped land west of the city
- Demographically diverse - 58% white, 27% native, 8% hispanic

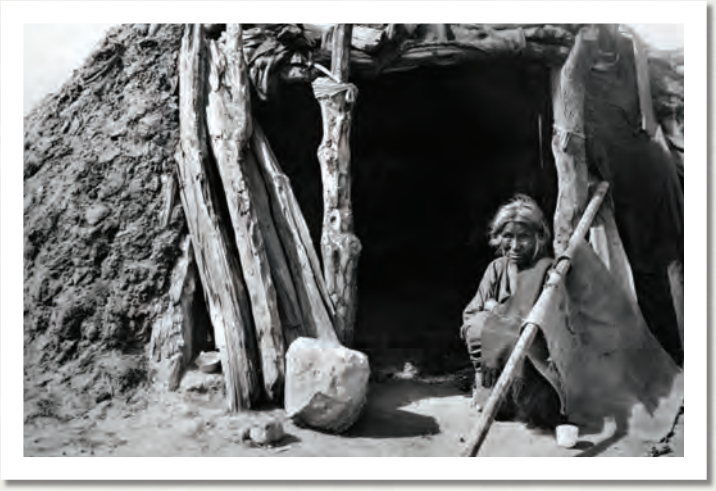
Blanding in 2025

3,300
Population

1,096
Households

Rich History

The city has a rich and layered history. It sits on lands once inhabited by Ancestral Puebloan people and maintains close cultural ties to Ute and Navajo communities. Blanding was later established by Mormon settlers, and today, the city reflects a blend of Indigenous heritage, settler history, and rural identity. The Edge of the Cedars State Park Museum, located west of downtown, is a key cultural anchor and houses the largest collection of Ancestral Puebloan artifacts in the region.



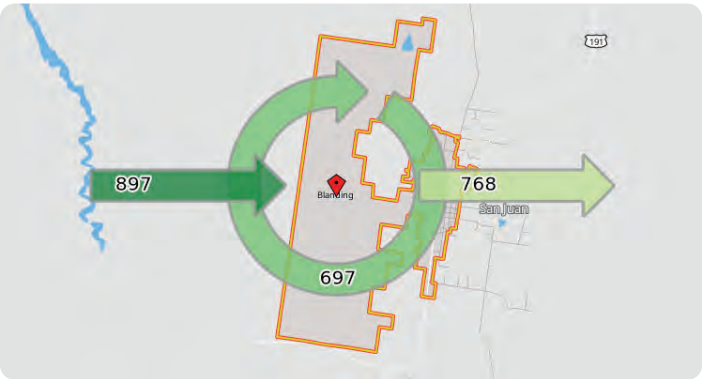
Navajo Woman, C1901. /Nan Elderly Navajo Woman Seated In The Doorway Of A Hogan, A Traditional Dwelling, In The Southwestern United States. Photograph, C1901. Poster Print by Granger Collection

Photo credit: UVU Instagram

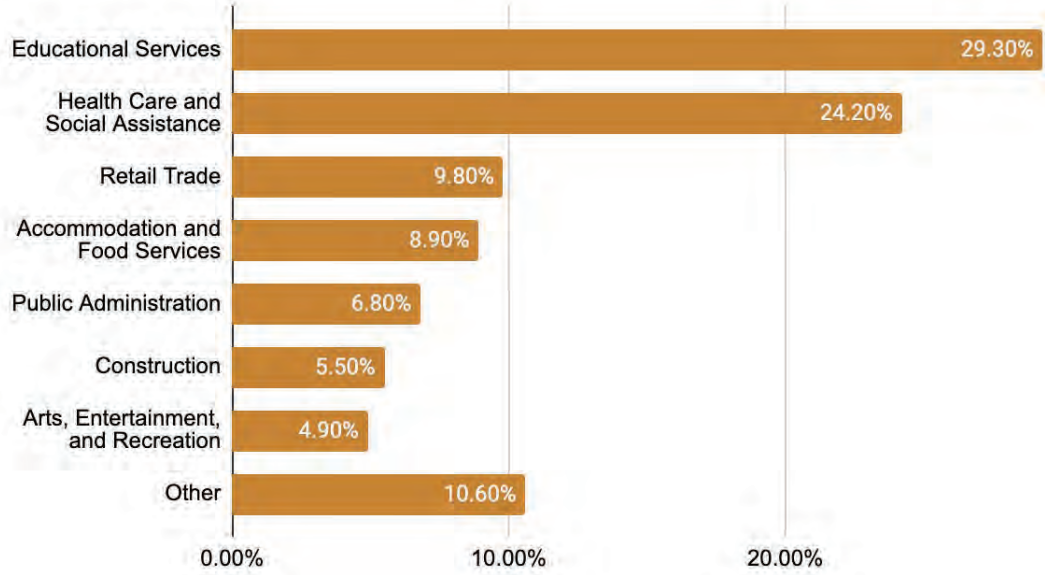
Gateway To The Four Corners Region.

Employment

Blanding's largest employment sectors are education (29.3%) and health care and social assistance (24.2%), followed by retail and tourism-related services. Many of these jobs are based downtown, which is the city's only commercial zone. About 697 residents live and work within Blanding, 768 residents live in the city but work elsewhere, and 897 people commute into the city for work.



Blanding Labor Market Segment



Tourism is becoming a larger part of the city's economy thanks to nearby public lands and recreation destinations. At the same time, residents and city leaders are cautious. They want to capture the economic benefits of visitors without losing Blanding's small town livability. There is broad support for investments that improve the experience for both locals and visitors, especially projects that strengthen walkability, enhance the streetscape, and support existing businesses.

The downtown core retains many of the hallmarks of a traditional small-town main street, and yet these strengths are undercut by significant challenges.

The downtown core retains many of the hallmarks of a traditional small-town main street, and yet these strengths are undercut by significant challenges.

Strengths

Compact blocks that support walkability.

Engaging buildings set close to the sidewalk.

Existing street trees, outdoor seating, and murals.

Local businesses with unique character.

Challenges

Several abandoned and rundown buildings.

Vacant and oversized parking lots that disrupt walkability.

Wide, high-speed streets with very few pedestrian crossings.

Many office and service businesses that lack active frontages.

Alignment with the General Plan

Blanding City updated its general plan in 2024. The General Plan reflects community priorities around preserving rural character, increasing housing options, and strengthening the local economy.

Key points from the General Plan that relate to this Downtown Plan:

- **Preserving small-town feel** while accommodating mixed-use development and higher-density housing especially along the highway corridor.
- **Diversifying commercial activity** by adding more restaurants and retail uses.
- **Focusing on infill development**, prioritizing parcels near existing infrastructure to avoid the cost and inefficiency of outward expansion.
- **Improving walkability and connectivity**, with strong demand for traffic calming, sidewalks, and trails.
- **Enhancing the highway corridor** with landscaping, site furniture, public art, and a defined gateway experience.
- **Housing access** as a workforce issue, with employers noting that limited housing options make it difficult to attract and retain staff.

Community Engagement

This plan is grounded in feedback and insights from community members, city staff, and stakeholders.

- **Community Workshop** - The planning team hosted a community workshop on May 15 at the Blanding City Office. This workshop included a presentation about downtown best practices and a discussion to identify downtown opportunities and challenges.
- **Online Survey** - The planning team worked with Blanding City to distribute an online survey via the city newsletter and utility bills. This survey was open June 1 to 30 and asked respondents for suggestions and priorities related to downtown land use, transportation, and amenities.

Key Insights:

Community and Branding

- **PUBLIC ART:** Value in public art to reflect local identity. Examples include:
  - Murals by Kelly Pugh and Nikki Saffrit.
  - Youth-led public art projects and local art shows
  - Murals as wayfinding (to USU and Edge of Cedars)
  - Large "Blanding" archway (like Brigham City)
- **PARK UPGRADES:** Update and upkeep of parks and public spaces. Add new trees and landscaping to parks.
- **COMMUNITY HUB:** Desire for a stronger "center" or public gathering spot. More activities for youth and families and events to bring people downtown.
- **LOCAL ECONOMY:** Support local businesses and use caution against heavy reliance on chain stores.
- **FOOD TRUCK PARK:** Food truck park in vacant lot.

Important Destinations

- **HISTORIC AND CULTURAL LANDMARKS:** South Chapel, Redd's Ace Hardware, old bank building, San Juan Theater, San Juan Pharmacy, the Flower Shop, Blanding Visitor Center, and the Blanding Public Library.
- **LOCAL BUSINESSES AND AMENITIES:** Clark's Market, Family Dollar, Higher Grounds Coffee, Creamy Delights, Canyon Country Bowling Center, A&W, Centennial Park and Wellness Center.

Wayfinding

- **WAYFINDING IMPROVEMENTS:** Better directional signage to parks, the library, museums, reservoirs, Bears Ears, USU, etc.
- **TRAVELER SIGNAGE:** Highway-style amenity boards to attract travelers.
- **COLLEGE VISIBILITY** College town wayfinding emphasis (USU signs are too small).

Key Insights:

Land Use / Building Design

- **HISTORIC CHARACTER:** Preserve the "small town" charm with building design. Preserve the historical character of Blanding. Match historical/rock style and avoid mismatched modern architecture.
- **DOWNTOWN DECAY:** Too many vacant, run down buildings and empty parking lots. Causing downtown to feel empty, closed, and lacking vibrancy. Trash, weeds, and overgrown landscaping accumulates.
- **LIMITED OPTIONS:** Limited dining and shopping: Not enough restaurants, variety in retail stores, and a lack of some basic services (e.g., barber shop).
- **MIXED-USE GROWTH:** More variety and mixed use: live work options and mixed use buildings.

Traffic Safety

- **INTERSECTION SAFETY:** Replace/upgrade Main & Center four-way stop with traffic light. Often feels unsafe, confusing, and awkward.
- **TRAFFIC CONTROL:** Add stop/yield signs at more intersections.
- **SPEED MANAGEMENT:** Slower speeds in pedestrian heavy areas.

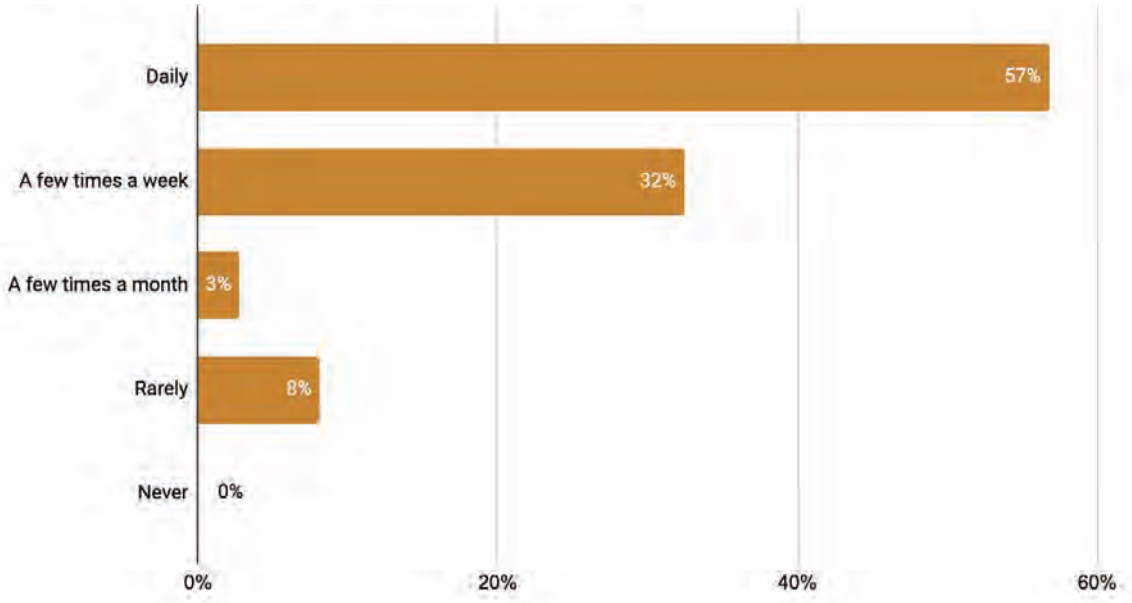
Street Amenities

- **BIKE PARKING:** More bike racks (e.g. Bowling Alley).
- **OUTDOOR SEATING:** Need for outdoor seating (Bowling Alley, A&W, ice cream spots). More pleasant places to sit and hangout.
- **DOWNTOWN GREENING:** More greenery, flowers, and landscaping improvements. More trees to provide shade (especially in Southern downtown).

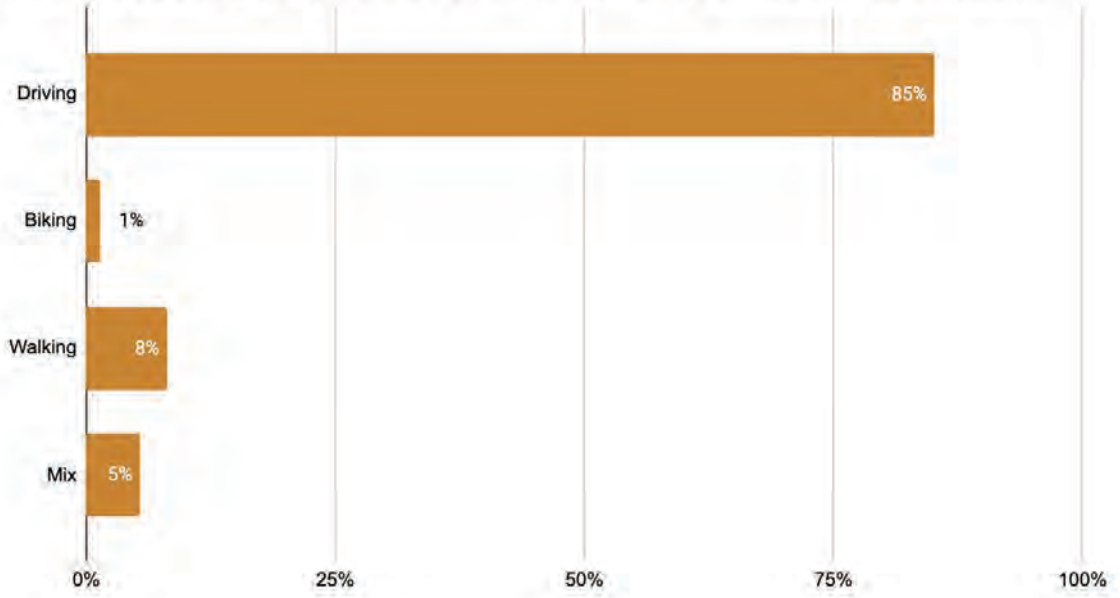
Walking and Biking

- **CROSSWALK SAFETY:** Few crosswalks. Need for more crosswalks on Main Street, Center Street, and near parks. Lighted signs or crossing flags at crosswalks.
- **SIDEWALK GAPS:** Fill gaps in the sidewalk network. Maintain overgrown weeds and landscaping intruding into walkways.
- **NARROW WALKWAYS:** Sidewalks are narrow. Especially on Center Street.
- **TRAIL CONNECTIONS:** Walking and biking trail that connects downtown to surrounding areas.
- **STREET LIGHTING:** Ensure street lighting is sufficient throughout downtown.

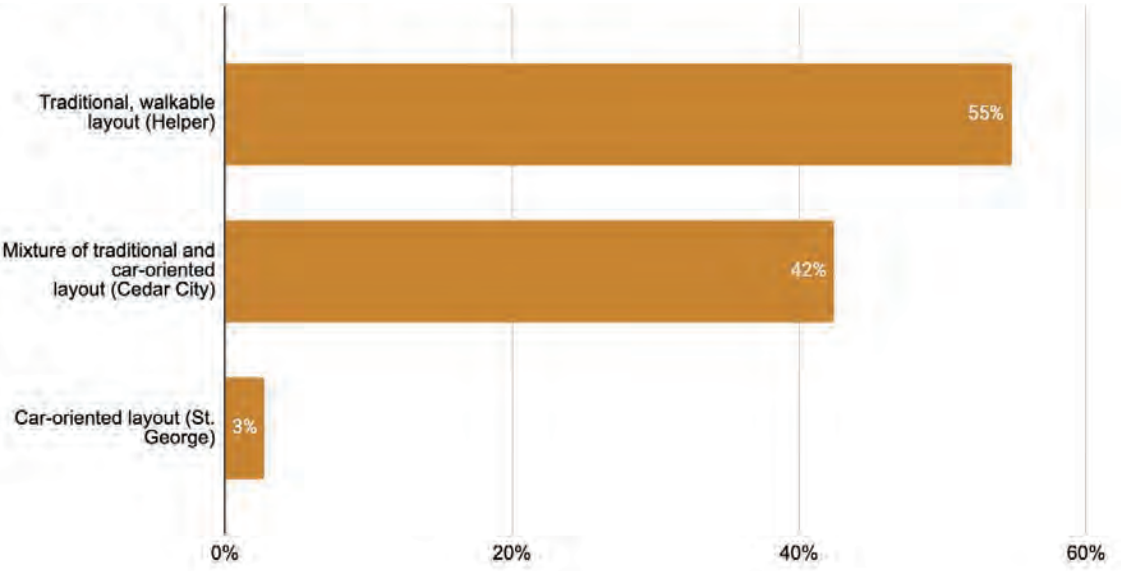
How often do you visit Downtown Blanding?



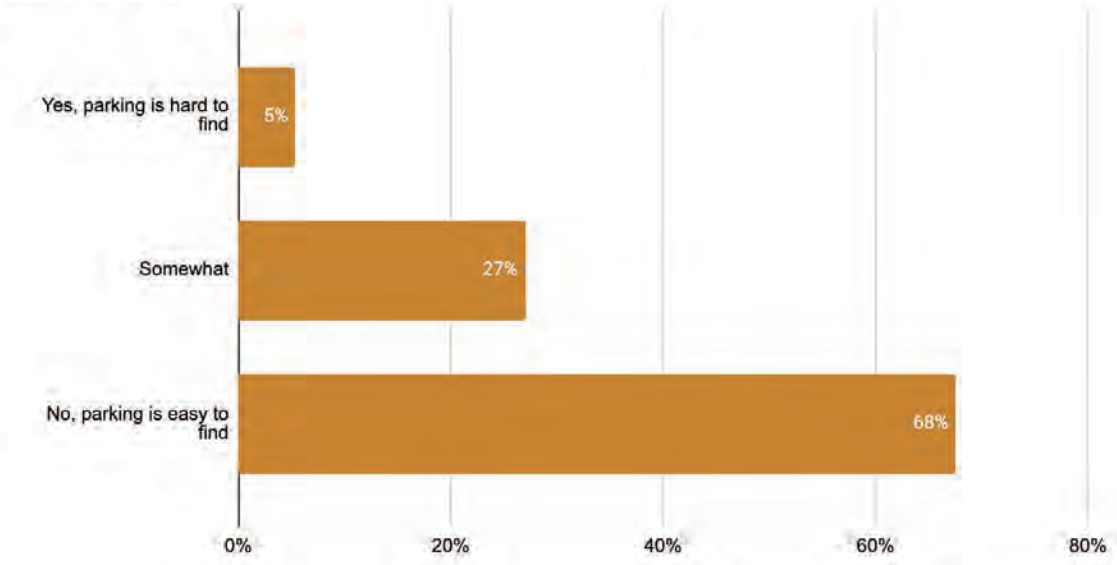
How do you typically access businesses or destinations Downtown?



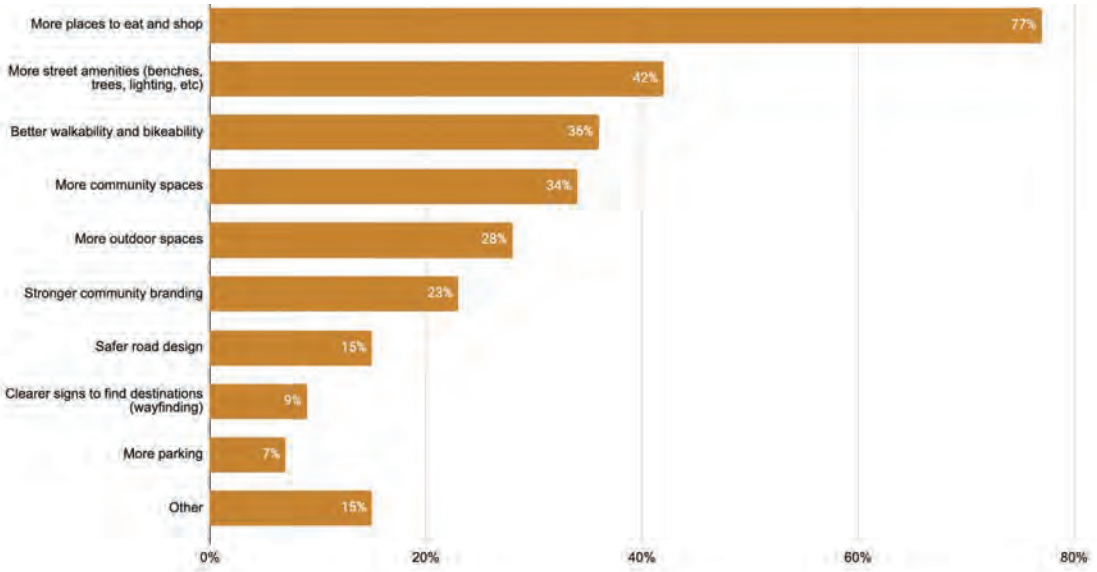
Which of these examples most closely matches the kind of downtown you would like to see in Blanding?



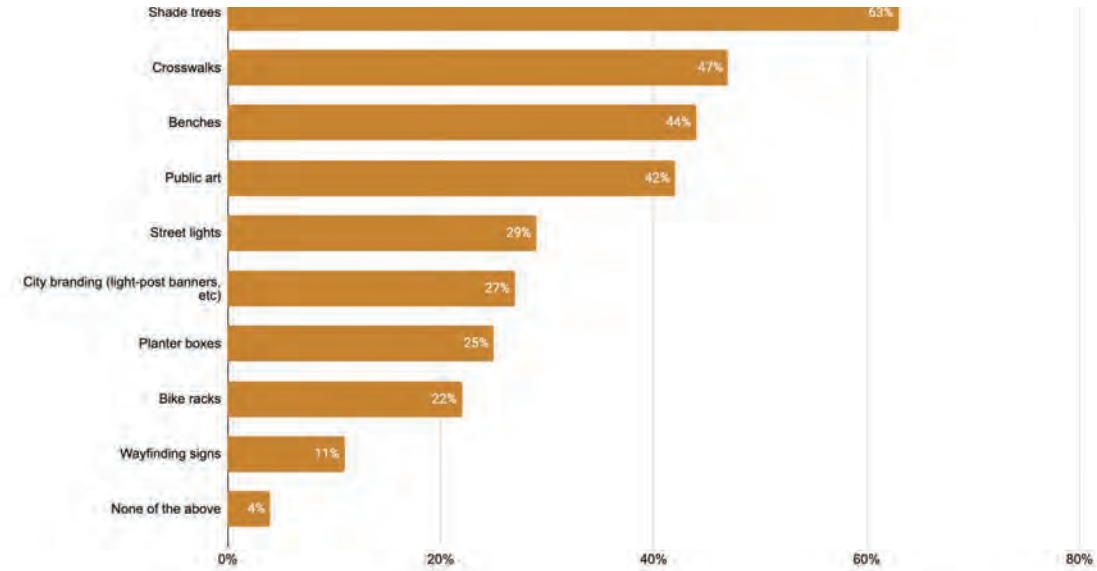
Is vehicle parking availability an issue for you in Downtown Blanding?



Which aspects of Downtown Blanding should be the highest priority for improvements? (select up to three)



Which street amenity would you most like to see in downtown Blanding? (select up to three)



Qualities of a Great Downtown

Great downtowns don't happen by accident. They are the product of deliberate choices about land use and building standards, business types, street design, and public space. Cities that invest in their downtowns build places where residents want to gather, businesses want to locate, and visitors want to linger.

- **WALKABILITY:** A walkable downtown is the foundation of economic success. When people can stroll safely and comfortably, they spend more time and more money. Streets that prioritize pedestrians create better conditions for businesses and support social interaction.

- **MIXED USE:** The most vibrant downtowns have a healthy mix of uses—retail, housing, offices, and civic space—bringing life to the area throughout the day and into the evening. Mixed-use development ensures people are around not just from 9 to 5, but during weekends, evenings, and events.

- **HUMAN-SCALED DESIGN:** Engaging storefronts, frequent windows and doors, and minimal setbacks encourage people to walk, explore, and connect. Downtown building standards should require active ground-floor uses that contribute to the streetscape.

- **PUBLIC SPACES:** Downtowns thrive when people can gather. Cafés, plazas, libraries, and shaded benches invite residents to meet, rest, and socialize. These "third places" (neither home nor work) strengthen community bonds and encourage repeat visits.

- **PLACEMAKING AND IDENTITY:** Downtowns should be unique, memorable places shaped that lean into their history and culture. Public art, wayfinding signs, landscaping, and distinct architecture can help express the story of the community.

Utah Examples

KANAB, UTAH

Downtown Kanab, Utah, is a vibrant, walkable, and human-scaled small-town core that blends mixed-use development, placemaking, and a strong sense of identity.

Center Street serves as its heart, with a compact layout of locally owned shops, galleries, eateries, hotels, and public amenities all within easy walking distance. This mix supports residents and visitors alike while preserving historic storefronts and approachable design.

Kanab's "Little Hollywood" heritage—rooted in more than 130 films and TV shows—is woven into the streetscape through the Little Hollywood Walk of Fame, preserved film sets, and attractions like the Little Hollywood Museum. Public life thrives through events such as the Kanab Outdoor Market, weekly farmers markets, and the Western Legends Heritage Music Festival.

Historic landmarks like the 1929 Kanab Hotel and Café, Parry Lodge, and the Bowman–Chamberlain Heritage House anchor the streetscape, reinforcing character and continuity. Framed by striking red-rock cliffs and serving as a base for nearby national parks, downtown Kanab offers an authentic, connected, and lively environment that reflects its heritage while supporting everyday life.

Utah Examples

HELPER, UTAH

Helper, Utah is often highlighted as a model for a thriving small-town downtown due to its thoughtful blend of historic preservation, active street life, and walkable design. The city has preserved and restored its historic building facades, maintaining architectural integrity while allowing for adaptive reuse, which supports a mix of businesses including art galleries, coffee shops, restaurants, and specialty retail.

The street design prioritizes pedestrians with wide sidewalks, safe crossings, and traffic-calming measures that encourage slower vehicle speeds, making the downtown comfortable to navigate on foot. Public spaces such as plazas, pocket parks, and outdoor seating areas are integrated into the urban fabric, fostering community interaction and supporting events that activate the street. Clear wayfinding, attractive landscaping, and public art further enhance the downtown's sense of place.

Notable Locations:

- WPA-era post office with its iconic mural.
- The Conoco gas station converted into a photo-op and Airbnb.
- The Helper Museum and Mining Equipment Display.
- Boulder Park Riverwalk.

Utah Examples

VERNAL, UTAH

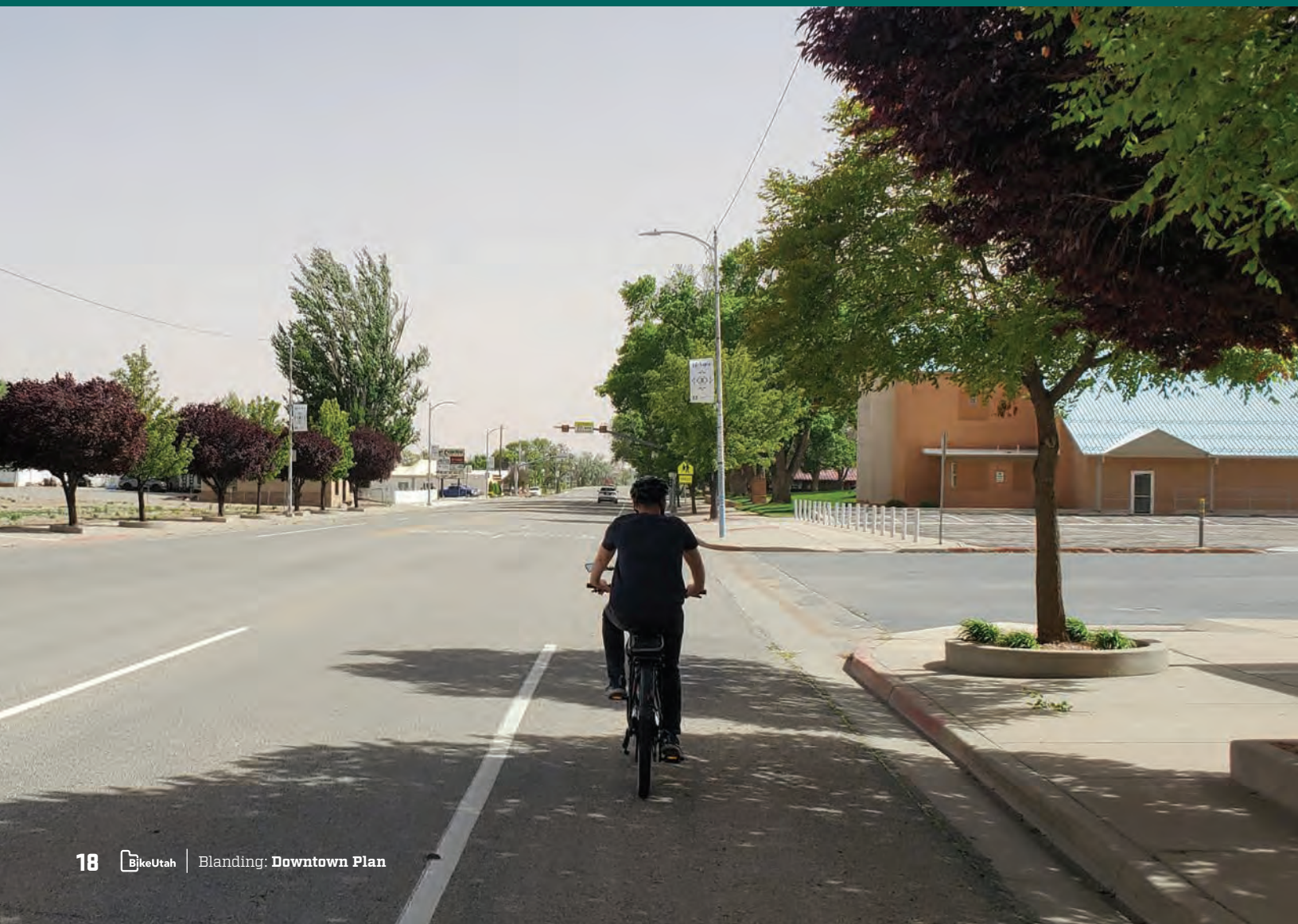
Downtown Vernal, Utah, is transforming into a more walkable, mixed-use, and human-scaled district while embracing its "Dinosaur Land" identity. Main Street remains the commercial core, lined with shops, restaurants, cultural attractions, and historic landmarks, though its highway function poses pedestrian challenges.

The city's Downtown Plan targets streetscape upgrades, public spaces, and mixed-use development, with projects like the renovated Zions Block, ongoing Cobble Rock block improvements, and planned Vernal Avenue enhancements featuring wider sidewalks, street trees, diagonal parking, and safer crossings. A 2021 zoning change allows ground-floor retail with upper-story housing, seen in Jurassic Heights and Raptor Heights.

The downtown's character is anchored by the 40-foot pink Dine-A-Ville Dinosaur, historic sites such as St. Paul's Episcopal Church, the Vernal Tithing Office, the Utah Field House of Natural History with its Dinosaur Garden, and the Parcel-Post Bank. Public spaces like Cobble Rock Park add fountains, planters, and art, while proximity to Dinosaur National Monument, McConkie Ranch, and other outdoor destinations reinforces Vernal's distinct sense of place and supports its revitalization.

CHAPTER

02 Transportation

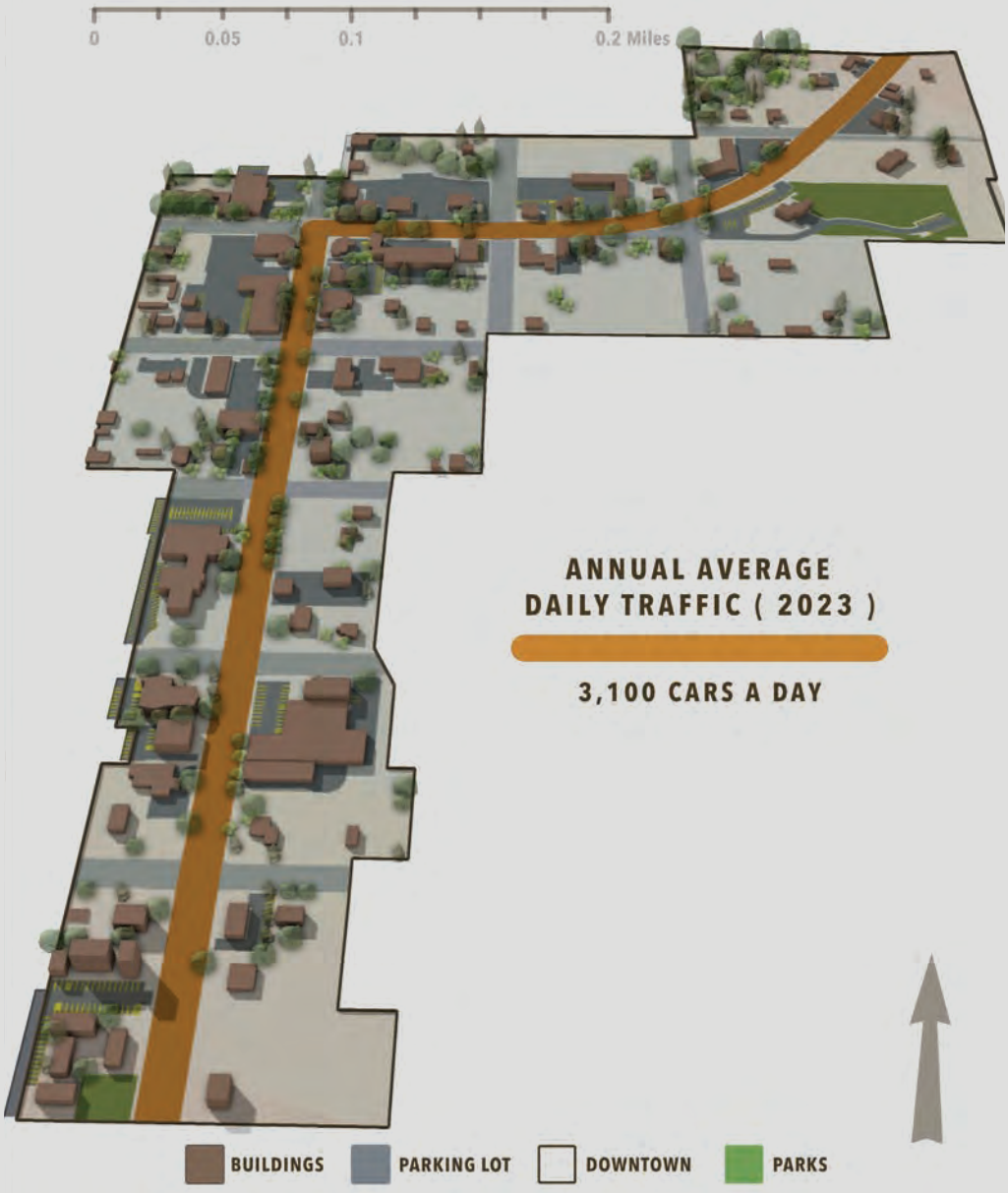


Existing Conditions

Streets aren't just for moving vehicles, they are public spaces that directly impact how people experience and access local destinations. Within a downtown context, it's especially important for road networks to be safe and comfortable for all road users.

This chapter examines the street network, sidewalks, bike infrastructure, parking, and related design elements of Blanding's transportation system. This chapter provides a set of recommendations to improve safety, comfort, and mobility in and around downtown.

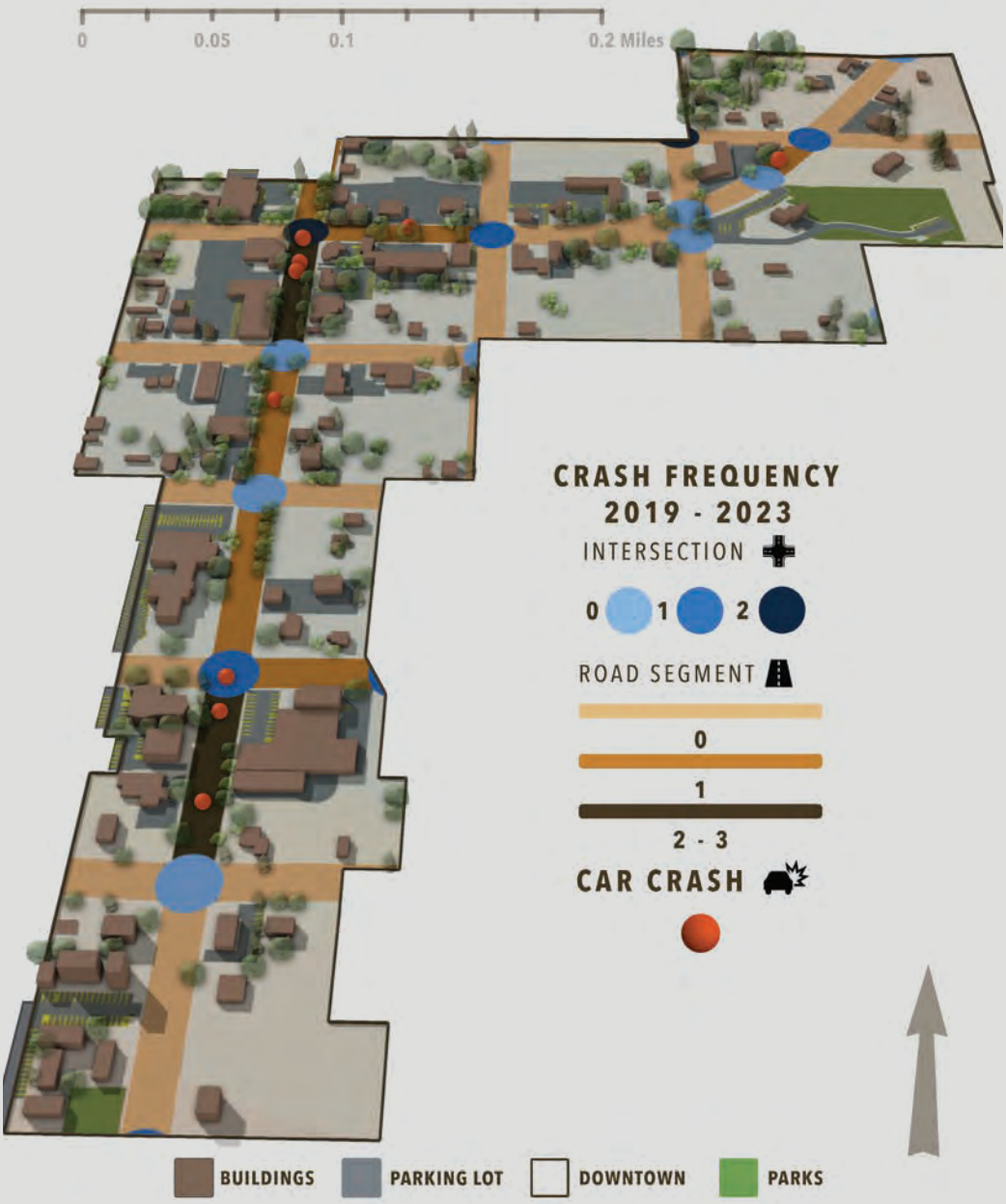
Road Characteristics: **Traffic**



Road Characteristics: **Speed**

Road Characteristics: **Road Width**

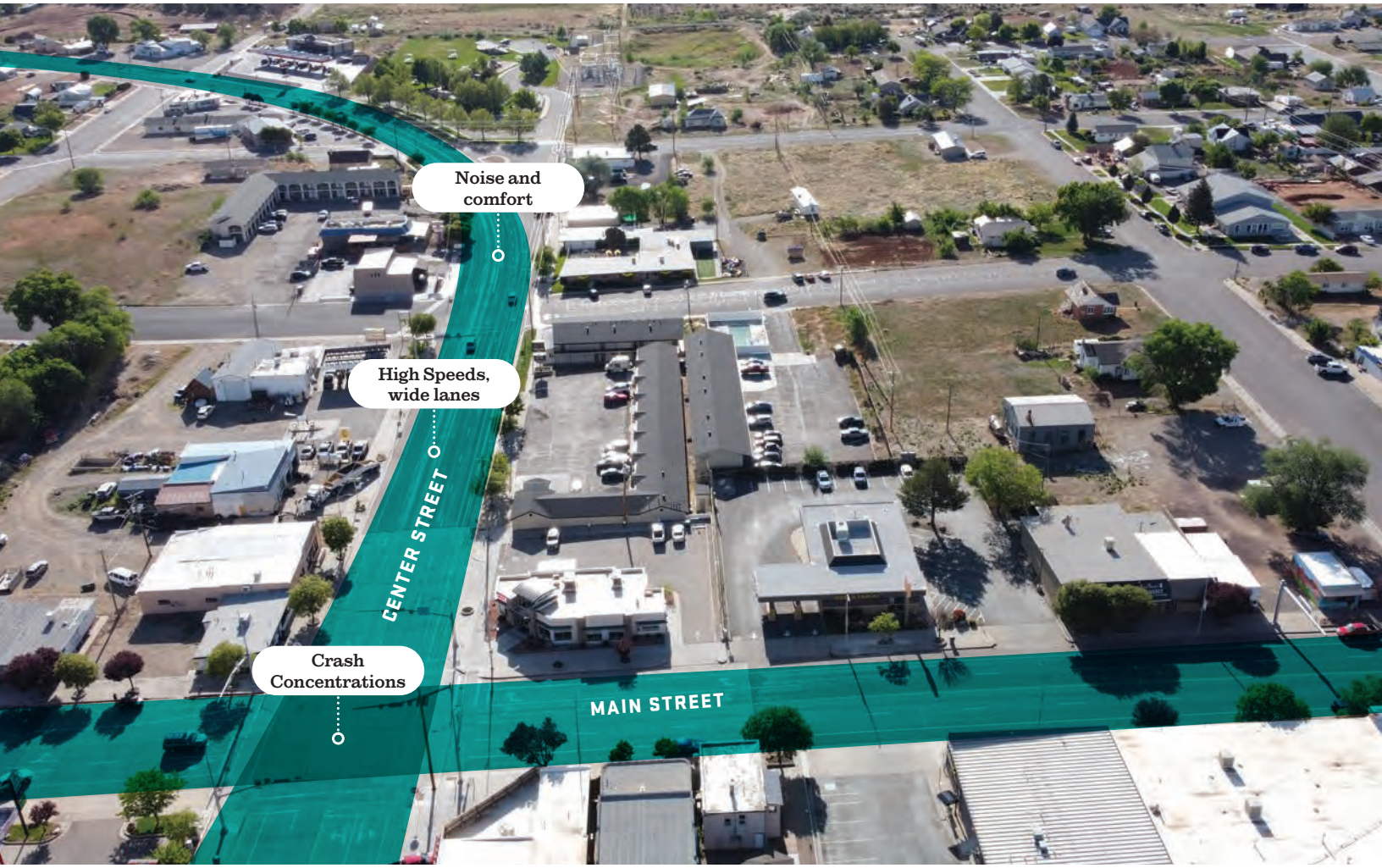
High Injury Network: **(Car Crashes 2019 - 2023)**



US-191

US-191 is the primary highway within Blanding, serving both local and regional traffic. Within the city, this road becomes Blanding's Main Street (north-south) and Center Street (east-west), forming a spine for the downtown commercial district.

For most of its length within the downtown, US-191 consists of four travel lanes, two in each direction, with approximately 12-ft lane widths. On-street parking is provided on both sides with 8-ft parking lanes.



Challenges:

HIGH SPEEDS, WIDE LANES: Despite being the commercial heart of Blanding, Main Street and Center Street function as regional highways with a posted speed of 30 mph and moderate daily traffic of roughly 3,100 vehicles per day. The width and number of lanes encourage faster driving and make crossings uncomfortable for pedestrians.

CRASH CONCENTRATION: All reported car crashes in Blanding from 2019-2023 occurred along US-191, highlighting its safety issues.

NOISE AND COMFORT: Noise and comfort are ongoing concerns. Fast moving traffic creates constant noise that makes outdoor seating and storefront areas less inviting.

Recommendations:

PURSUE A 4-TO-3 LANE ROAD DIET: Work with UDOT to convert the downtown segment of US-191 from 4 lanes to 3 (1 lane in each direction with a center turn lane). This configuration would calm traffic, shorten crossings, and improve pedestrian safety with minimal impact on regional traffic. This treatment is supported by UDOT conditional on City Council approval.

IMPROVE EXISTING CROSSINGS (X6): Upgrade pedestrian crossings at the 4-way stop, 100 E, and 300 S to improve visibility and safety. Refresh pavement markings, install rectangular rapid-flashing beacons (RRFBs), and add curb extensions where feasible. Coordinate with UDOT to preserve the 300 S crossing even after the elementary school relocates.

INSTALL NEW HIGH-VISIBILITY CROSSINGS (X5): Work with UDOT to evaluate feasibility of adding new pedestrian crossings at 100 S, 200 S, 500 S, 100 N, and 200 N. These new crossings are needed to improve safety and connectivity across US-191.

LONG-TERM OPPORTUNITY: REROUTING US-191

Blanding City may consider rerouting regional traffic away from the downtown. This approach would likely require a formal traffic study to assess feasibility and significant coordination with UDOT. Key challenges include addressing impacts to residential properties along the new alignment and upgrading road infrastructure to support higher volumes.

This idea was requested by residents during the community workshop and would allow Main Street and Center Street to function more like local streets, better supporting walkability and business access.

Local Roads

There are 10 local roads that intersect with Blanding's Downtown. These streets are all 25 mph and generally 64 feet wide configured with one travel lane in each direction and on-street parking on both sides - often angled or perpendicular parking. These local streets lack lane striping except for short segments on Main Street and Center Street near the signalized intersection.

For most of its length within the downtown, US-191 consists of four travel lanes, two in each direction, with approximately 12-ft lane widths. On-street parking is provided on both sides with 8-ft parking lanes.

Challenges:

INCONSISTENT DESIGN: Local streets vary in parking layout, curb treatments, lighting, and landscaping, giving the downtown a fragmented appearance.

WIDE CROSSINGS: The 64ft width creates long pedestrian crossing distances and also encourages faster vehicle traffic.

LIMITED PEDESTRIAN INFRASTRUCTURE: Many local streets lack sidewalks, curb ramps, and defined crossings, making pedestrian movement less comfortable.

Recommendations:

IMPROVE LOCAL STREET DESIGN: Establish standard design elements for local streets to visually link these areas to the downtown. This may include parking layout, curbs, sidewalks, lighting, street trees, and crosswalks. See Chapter 4 for more recommendations on street amenities.

INSTALL SIDEWALKS: Construct 1 mile of new sidewalks within the downtown.

CONSIDER ANGLED PARKING ON SELECT BLOCKS: Where appropriate, introduce angled parking to increase parking supply. This also visually narrows the road and can be easier for drivers to access compared to parallel parking.

STRIPE TRAVEL LANES AND PARKING STALLS: Add lane striping and clearly mark parking spaces on local streets with higher traffic to improve organization and driver behavior.

MARK LOCAL STREET CROSSINGS (X16): Outside of the 4-way stop, no marked crossings currently exist across local streets. Paint transverse (two-line) crosswalks at these intersections to improve pedestrian safety and connectivity. Consider curb extensions as well to shorten crossing distances.

Parking

Parking access is important for residents, visitors, and businesses. Easy access supports economic activity and makes the downtown more convenient to visit, particularly for visitors traveling long distances to get to Blanding.

However, within a downtown context, parking should be carefully balanced with walkability needs. Too much off-street parking can spread destinations farther apart, increase walking distances, and diminish the sense of place that makes a downtown feel vibrant.

Downtown Blanding has a substantial supply of parking, both paved and unpaved. A review of parking lots within the downtown area identified approximately 11.5 acres of paved parking and 2.3 acres of gravel or dirt lots. Assuming about 500 square feet per space (including drive aisles and maneuvering room), this equates to roughly 1,200 off-street parking spaces — about 1,000 paved and 200 gravel/dirt.

Community input aligns with these findings: 68% of survey respondents said parking is easy to find, compared to 27% who said it is somewhat an issue and 5% who said it is an issue.

Challenges:

EXCESS SUPPLY: The large number of parking spaces exceeds current demand, consuming valuable land that could otherwise support businesses, housing, or public space.

WALKABILITY BARRIERS: Large surface parking lots disrupt the pedestrian network and weaken downtown character, especially when surface parking lots front Main Street or Center Street.

DISCONNECTED LOTS: Many lots are separated by walls or fences, forcing pedestrians to walk around them rather than through, further reducing connectivity.

VISUAL QUALITY: Gravel and dirt lots detract from the downtown aesthetic, making the area feel unfinished or neglected.

Downtown Parking **(Paved vs Unpaved)**

Recommendations:

IMPROVE PARKING LOT DESIGN AND COMFORT: Work with businesses to upgrade parking lots with defined pedestrian walkways, landscaping, shade trees, lighting, and striping to improve safety and visual quality. Where feasible, remove or modify walls and fences between adjacent parking lots to improve pedestrian connectivity

ENCOURAGE SHARED PARKING AGREEMENTS: Adjust zoning requirements to allow shared parking between businesses with different peak hours. Encourage businesses to adopt shared parking agreements where feasible.

REDEVELOP SURPLUS PARKING AREAS: Encourage infill development on underutilized parking lots, particularly those fronting Main Street or Center Street to create a more continuous, walkable street edge.

LONG-TERM OPPORTUNITY: DOWNTOWN PARKING GARAGE

In many downtowns, structured parking allows communities to free up valuable land for new development while still providing convenient access for visitors. A parking garage can consolidate scattered lots into a single shared facility, supporting growth and improving walkability.

In Blanding, a parking garage is not needed in the near term since parking supply is high and there is plenty of space available for new development. As the downtown becomes more developed over time, a parking garage may become more practical to support higher density businesses and housing.

Parking garages are expensive to build. They are often jointly funded by the city and downtown businesses who will all benefit from the project.

Example:

Provo, Utah Parking Garage

Active Transportation

Walking and biking are important components of vibrant downtowns. A comfortable walking and biking environment encourages people to visit local businesses, stay longer, and interact with their community. Walkable downtowns are also safer, quieter, and more visually appealing.

Blanding currently lacks a formal Active Transportation Plan, and its pedestrian and bicycle infrastructure is limited. The city's small size and compact grid provide a strong foundation for an active transportation network.

Challenges:

MISSING SIDEWALKS: Most local roads lack sidewalks. These gaps limit mobility and discourage walking to downtown businesses.

LIMITED CROSSINGS: Outside of the four-way stop at Main and Center, there are only two marked pedestrian crossings: one at 100 E and one at 300 S. The crossing at 300 S may be removed when the elementary school relocates.

NO BIKE INFRASTRUCTURE: There aren't any bike lanes, trails, or bike racks within the downtown. This is a lost opportunity considering how significant biking is as an outdoor recreation activity for tourists and residents in the area.

Recommendations:

DEVELOP AN ACTIVE TRANSPORTATION PLAN: Create a citywide plan that identifies walking and biking routes and prioritizes projects for funding and implementation. These routes will likely intersect with the Downtown area. This plan should align with regional trails in San Juan County.

DEVELOP SAFE ROUTES TO SCHOOL (SRTS) PLAN: Work with San Juan School District to create SRTS plan for the elementary and middle schools within Blanding. These routes will likely intersect with the downtown area and provide an opportunity to identify and implement additional safety improvements like sidewalks and crossings.

ESTABLISH MIDBLOCK WALKWAY NETWORK: Adopt the midblock walkway network identified in this plan to provide pedestrian connections between buildings and rear parking areas. Work with businesses to construct these paths around existing development. Incorporate midblock walkway requirements into the zoning code. As downtown grows, consider adopting additional midblock walkway alignments to new blocks as needed.

Sidewalk Network: **(Gap Analysis)**

Transportation Recommendations

Category	Actions	Length or #	Cost Description	Cost Estimate
US-191	Pursue a 4-to-3 lane road diet	0.8 mi	$50k per mile when coupled with road resurfacing (or $100k as a stand-alone project).	$40,000
	Improve existing crossings	6	Paint: $10 / linear ft. Curb extensions: $5,000 / corner RRFB: $10,000 / crosswalk	$43,600
	Install new high-visibility crossings (ladder)	5	Paint: $10 / linear ft. Curb extensions: $5,000 / corner RRFB: $10,000 / crosswalk	$103,000
Local Roads	Improve local street design	n/a	See chapter 4.	-
	Install sidewalks	1 mi	$40 / linear ft.	$211,200
	Mark local street crossings (transverse)	16	$2 / linear ft.	$1,900
	Stripe travel lanes and parking stalls	n/a	n/a	-
	Consider angled parking on select blocks	n/a	No cost	-
Parking	Redevelop surplus parking areas	n/a	No cost	-
	Encourage shared parking agreements	n/a	See chapter 3.	-
	Improve parking lot design and comfort	n/a	n/a	-
Active Transportation	Develop an Active Transportation Plan	1	$20k per plan	$20,000
	Develop Safe Routes to School (SRTS) Plan	1	$5k per plan	$5,000
	Establish midblock walkway network	0.65 mi	$140	$480,500
			Total Cost:	**$905,200**

CHAPTER

03 Land Use and Building Design

Existing Conditions

Land use determines the types of activities that are permitted within an area — such as retail, dining, offices, or housing — while building design shapes how those activities interact with the street and public realm. Together, they influence how people experience Blanding's downtown.

This chapter examines the current land use and building patterns in Blanding's Downtown and recommends zoning changes to make the area more vibrant and walkable. This includes a proposed Downtown Zone with updated zoning standards and design guidelines for development. Finally, the chapter presents illustrated concepts that show how these policies could look as Blanding's downtown develops.

Current Zoning

Downtown Blanding is currently zoned entirely as Commercial, with this being the only commercial district in the city.

Challenges:

AUTO-ORIENTED USES - Current zoning allows gas stations, auto repair shops, and used car sales lots that disrupt walkability and detract from the downtown's visual character.

NO MIXED-USE - Top-floor residential is not permitted, preventing compact, mixed-use development common in lively downtowns.

LARGE FRONT SETBACKS - The required 15-foot front setback pushes buildings away from the sidewalk, breaking the street edge.

RESTRICTIVE LOT COVERAGE - The maximum lot coverage of 60% is too low especially for small downtown parcels, limiting redevelopment potential.

EXCESSIVE PARKING REQUIREMENTS - High parking minimums contribute to the abundance of empty lots. The code does not allow shared parking or require rear placement of parking areas.

DISCONNECTED PARKING LOTS - Walls and fences between adjacent lots prevent access and pedestrian connections. There is also no plan for a midblock walkway network to improve internal circulation.

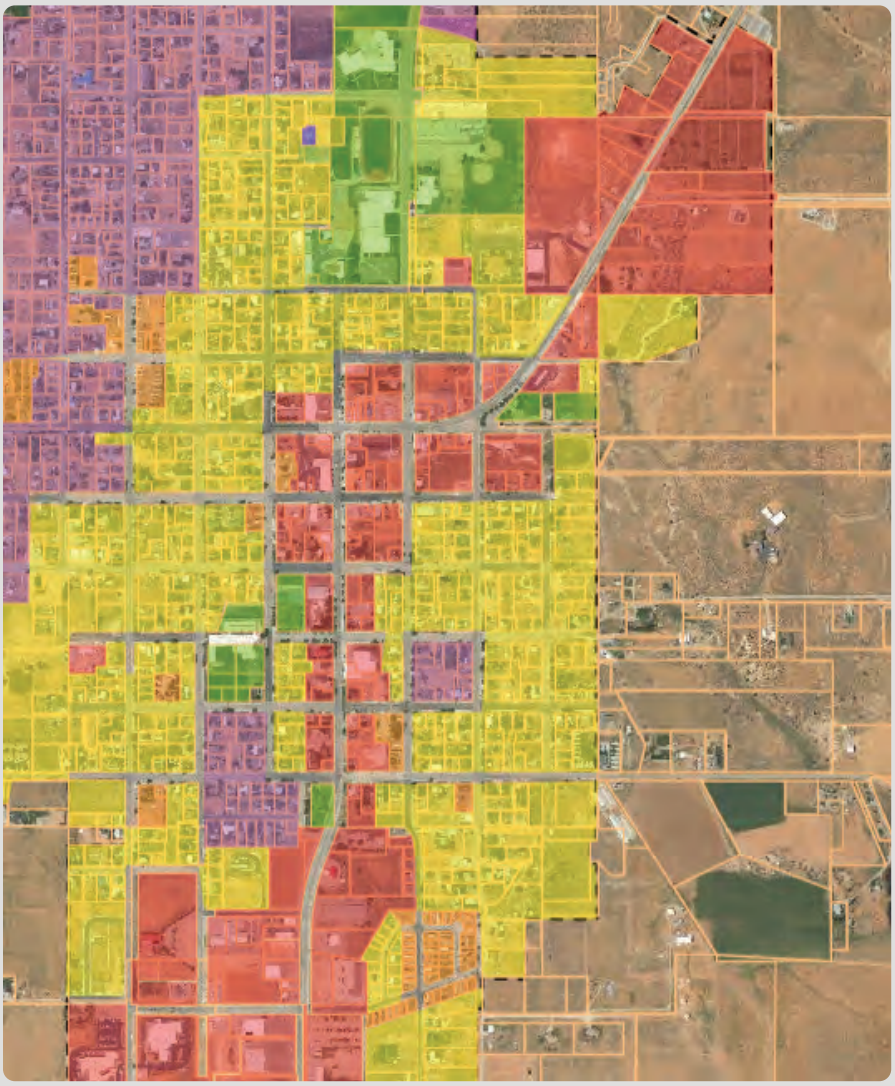
Recommendations:

ADOPT DOWNTOWN DISTRICT CODE AND DESIGN GUIDELINES: The proposed code supports walkable, mixed-use development and establishes clear standards for building placement, orientation, and design. See Appendix A and B.

ESTABLISH MIDBLOCK WALKWAY NETWORK: Build out the midblock walkway network identified in Chapter 2 to improve access between businesses and parking areas.

WORKING WITH PROPERTY OWNERS TO IMPROVE EXISTING LOTS: Partner with downtown businesses to bring older and nonconforming sites closer to new standards through facade improvements, infrastructure upgrades, shared parking agreements, and improved pedestrian spaces.

Current Zoning Code and Map



ZONES

- Commercial
- Mobile Homes
- Open Space
- Open Space-BLM
- Residential 1
- Residential 2

Current Land Use Mix

Blanding's downtown includes a variety of businesses and community destinations. An inventory of downtown buildings was completed and categorized by primary business type. These categories are shown on the accompanying map, along with a pie chart summarizing their relative proportions.

Key Findings:

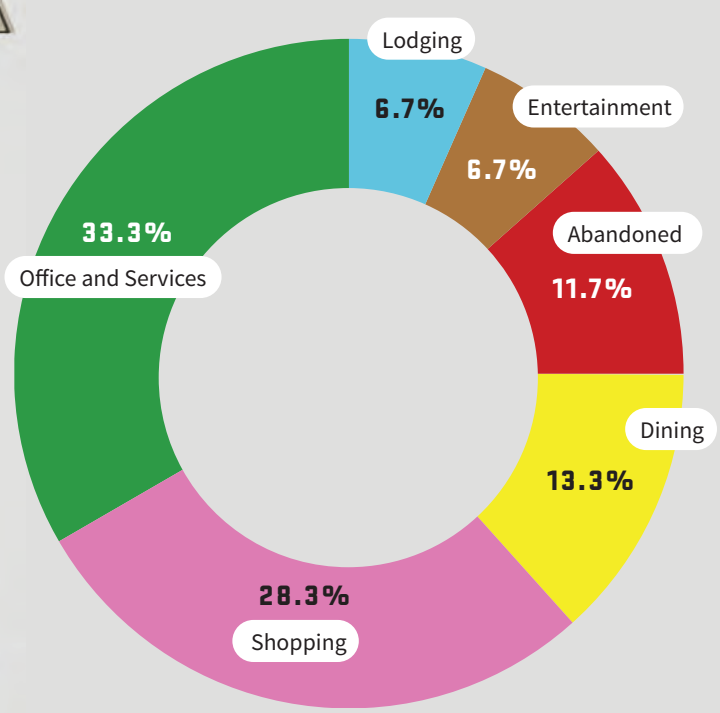
HIGH SHARE OF OFFICE AND SERVICE USES - One-third of businesses are office and service-oriented such as banks or healthcare offices. These uses are not ideal for a pedestrian-oriented downtown since they typically lack street-level activity. They are better suited as upper-story uses above active ground-floor shops or restaurants.

LIMITED SHOPPING AND DINING OPTIONS - Community survey responses for this plan indicate strong interest in more shopping and dining options to make downtown a more frequent destination.

HIGH VACANCY RATE - 12% of downtown buildings are abandoned, creating uninviting gaps in the street frontage.

Downtown Businesses **(By Category)**

Downtown building types (excluding residential)



Category	Location	
Shopping	• Dineh Designs Appeal • The Bakery Tanning Co • Verizon • Grayson General Store • Maverik • Bradford Tires • Redd's Ace Hardware • San Juan Pharmacy • Lyman's Enchanted Treasures	• NAPA Auto Parts • Creative Floors • Cedar Mesa Pottery • Cedar Mesa Gift Shop • Dollar General • H+ Aesthetics • The Flower Shop • Diamond Propane • Canyonlands Tire
Shopping	• Courtesy Loans • Laundromat • Zions Bank • RUCD Headstart • United States Postal Service • Zion's Way Home Health • Sun Shine Insurance • Red Mesa Home Health • Mesa Loans • Blanding City Office	• Pet Grooming • Desert Rivers Credit Union • Wells Fargo Bank • LDS Church • Primary Residential Mortgage • San Juan Mortuary • Four Corners Home Health • Recapture Investment Group • Craig C. Hall Office
Dining	• Patio Diner • Homestead Steak House • Dirty Pop • Hunt's Trading Post* • A&W Restaurant • Creamy Delights • Subway • Destination Awake	
Entertainment	• Visitor Center • Canyon Country Bowling Center • San Juan Theater • Blanding Public Library	
Lodging	• Four Corners Inn • Stone lizard Lodge • Bears Ears Inn • The Blue Sage Inn	
Abandoned	• West of Hunt's Trading Post • Diamond Stores • Antiques • Cyber Native Designs • Warehouse behind Destination Awake • Kung Pao Express • Next to Kung Pao Express	

Downtown District Zoning Code

The proposed downtown code provides standards to strengthen walkability, ensure consistent design, and support reinvestment within the downtown. The full text of the Downtown District Code is included in **Appendix A**.

Key Changes:

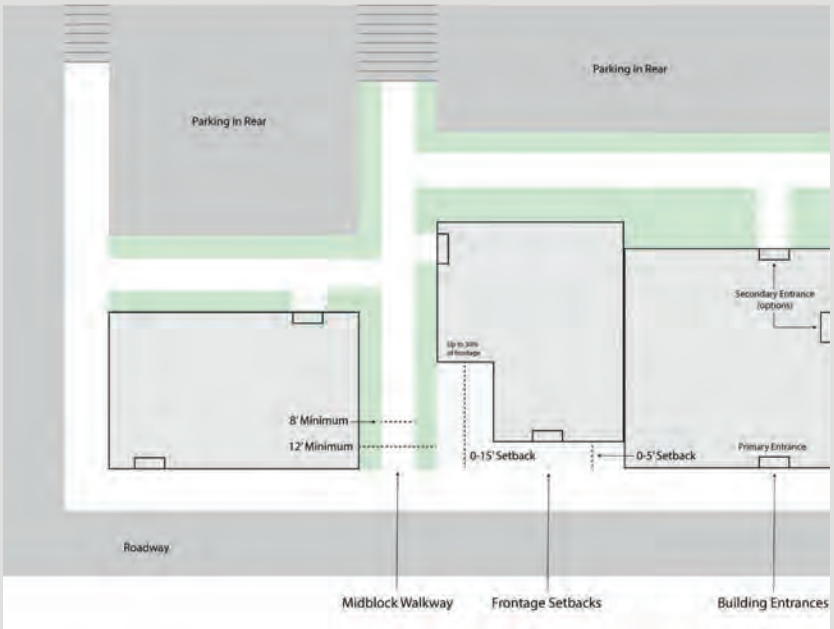
STRENGTHENS THE STREET EDGE - Reduces front setbacks to ensure buildings front the street and support pedestrian activity. Requires primary entrances to face the street, with service areas and parking located to the side or rear.

SUPPORTS PEDESTRIAN SPACES AND CONNECTIVITY - Requires that any areas within front or side setbacks not occupied by buildings be designed as pedestrian-oriented spaces, such as plazas, courtyards, or landscaped seating areas. Also incorporates a midblock walkway network and establishes connectivity standards between adjacent parking lots.

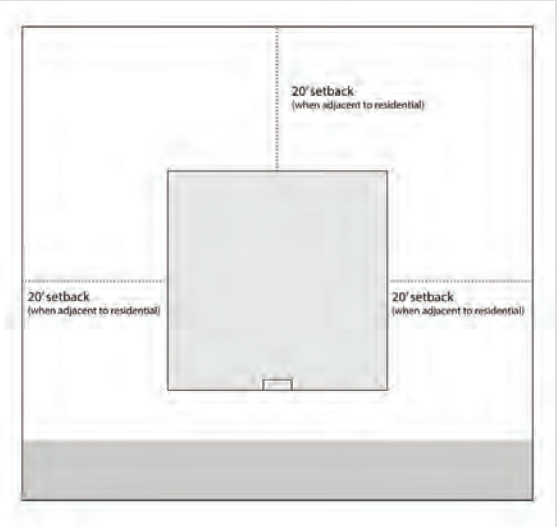
SUPPORTS SMALL-SCALE INFILL - Adjusts maximum coverage requirements to encourage infill development.

REDUCES PARKING REQUIREMENTS - Lowers parking minimums and allows shared parking agreements between properties to make more efficient use of existing spaces and reduce the number of underused lots.

ALLOWS MIXED-USE DEVELOPMENT - Allows residential uses on upper floors above ground-floor commercial to bring more activity throughout the day and evening.

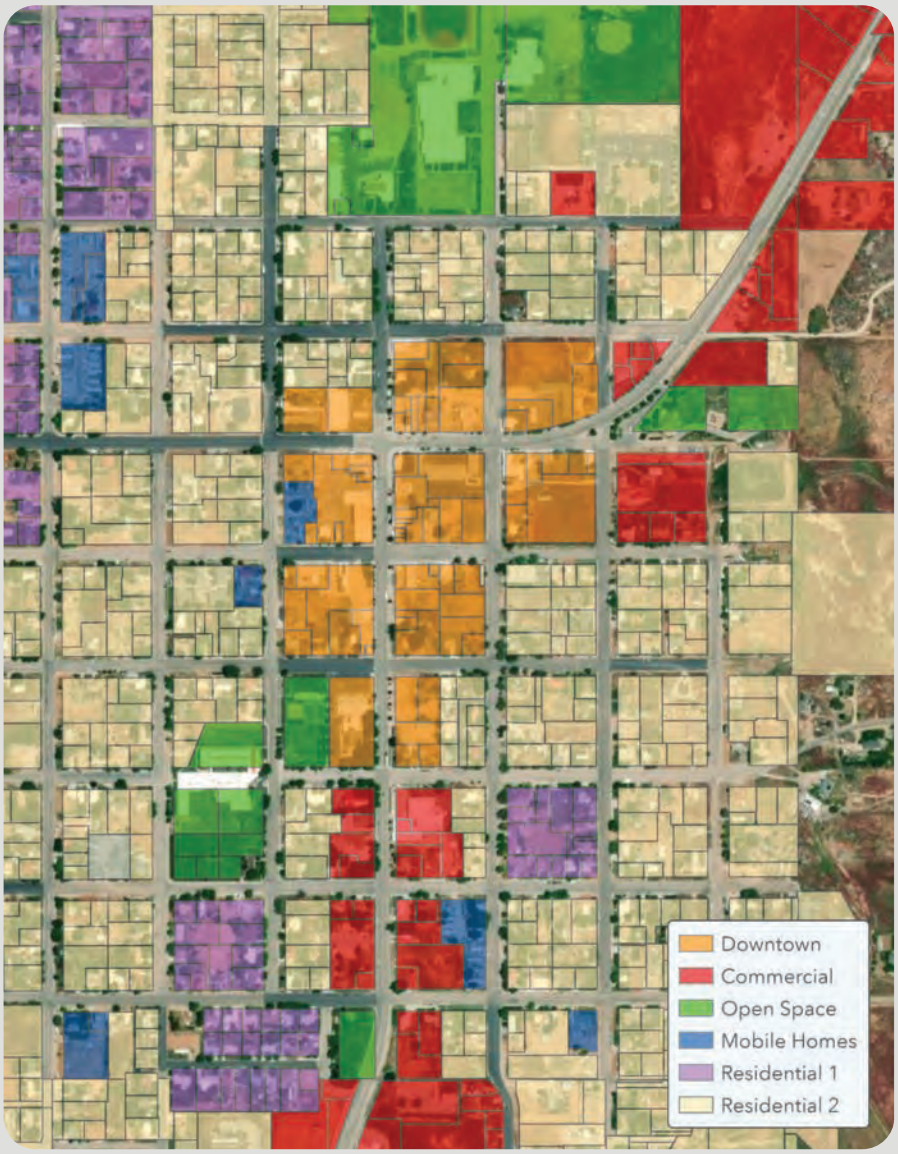


Downtown Zoning Requirements



Setbacks for neighboring residential parcels

Proposed downtown zone boundary



Downtown District Design Guidelines

The proposed downtown design guidelines provide direction for the layout and appearance of development. These guidelines are meant to supplement the Downtown District Zoning Code and focus on the character of development — how buildings, parking areas, and pedestrian spaces contribute to a cohesive downtown environment. The full guidelines are included in Appendix B.

Key Provisions:

SITE PLANNING – Encourages site layouts that respect existing site features, integrate open space, and create connections between buildings, parking areas, and sidewalks.

CIRCULATION PLANNING – Promotes efficient, user-friendly movement for vehicles, pedestrians, and cyclists by limiting curb cuts, encouraging shared access, and improving connectivity between properties.

PARKING AREAS – Recommends locating parking to the side or rear of buildings, linking lots between properties, and incorporating landscaping and walkways to reduce the visual scale of paved areas.

PEDESTRIAN SPACES – Supports outdoor dining areas, courtyards, plazas, and midblock walkways that enhance comfort, safety, and activity within the downtown.

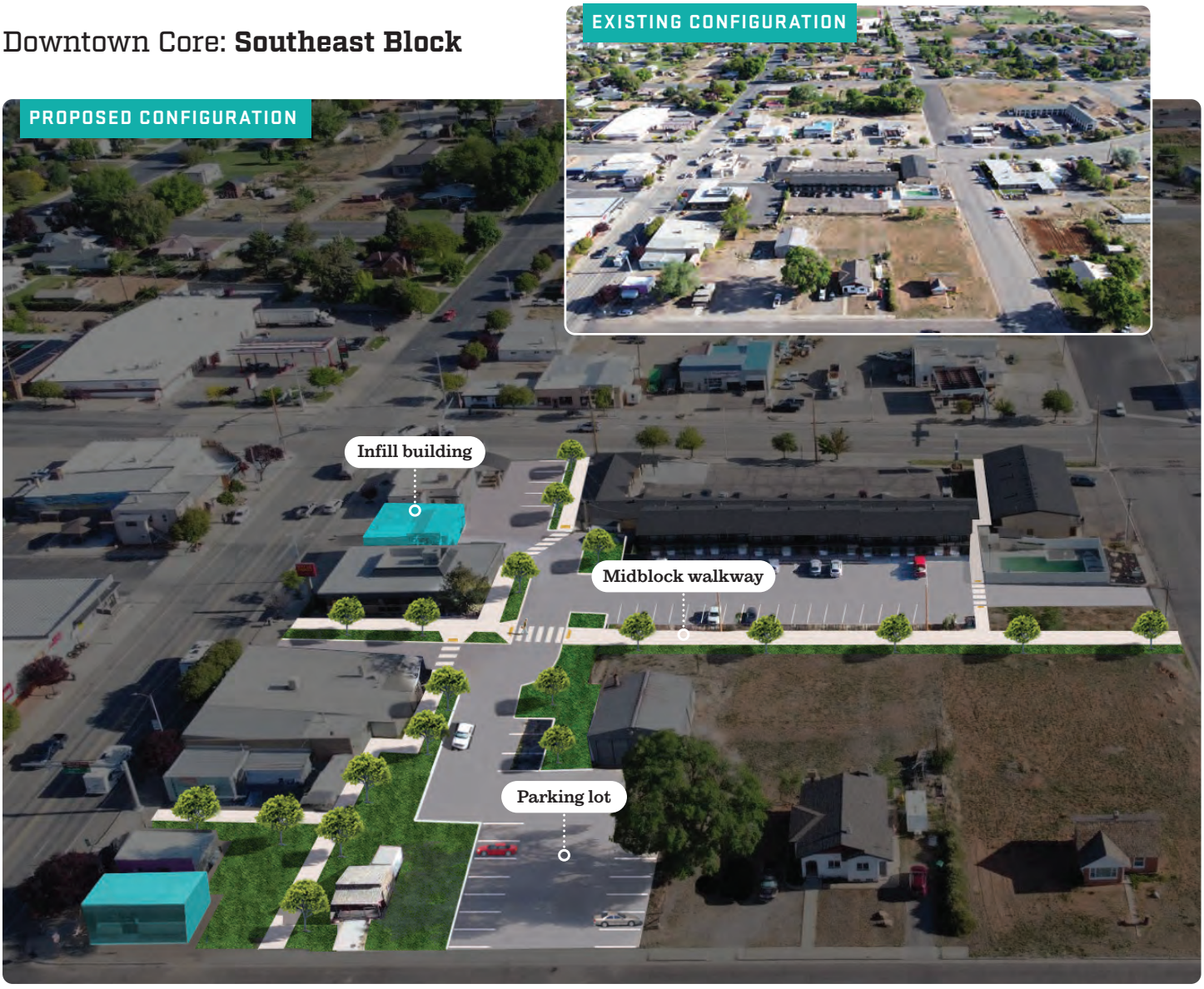
ARCHITECTURAL DESIGN – Provides guidance for building design, materials, transparency, and detailing to ensure new development is high-quality, human-scaled, and compatible with its surroundings.

Development Scenarios

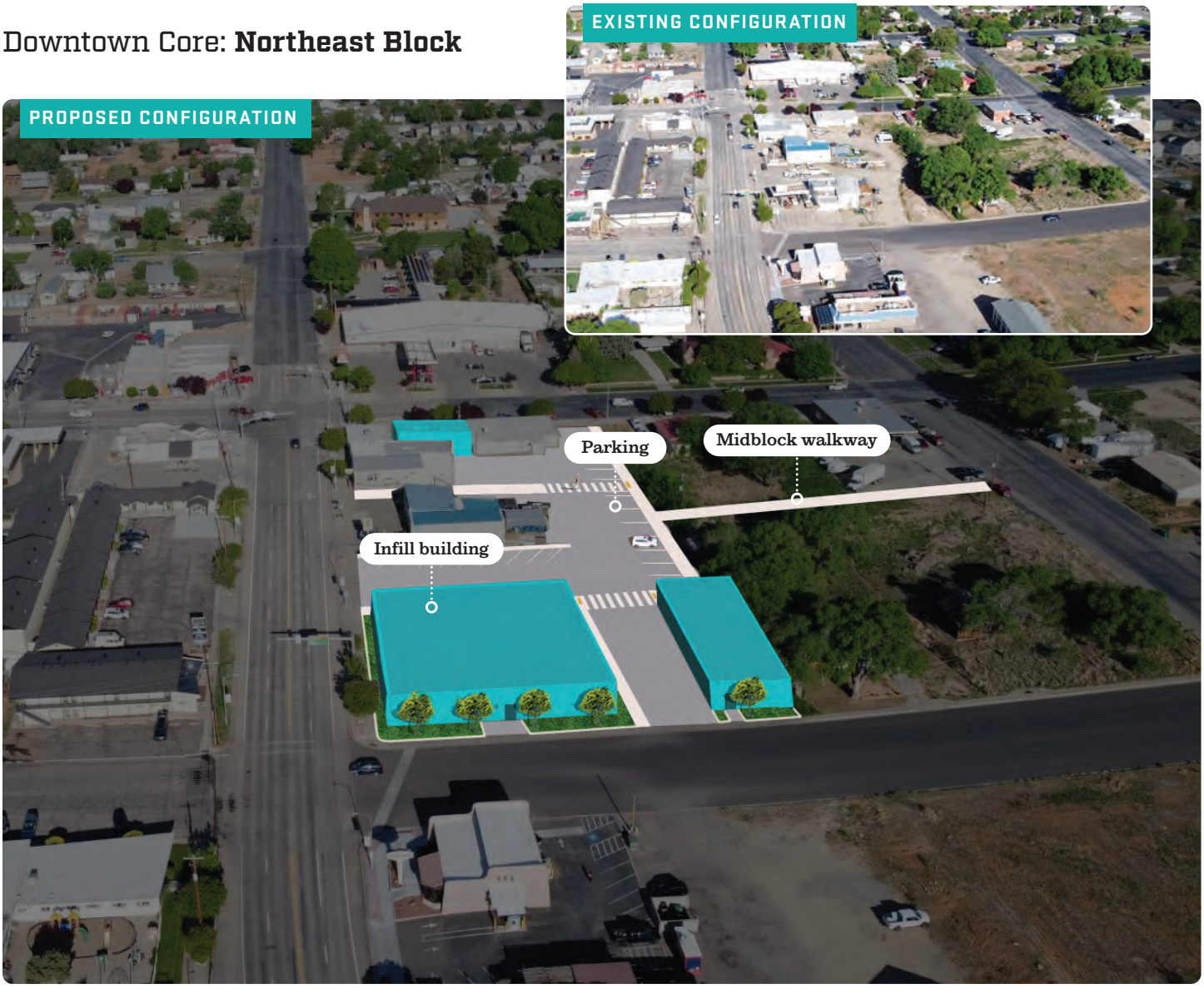
These visualizations are provided to show how proposed zoning and design guidelines could shape future development. These are not intended as final designs but as examples for how new buildings, parking lot layouts, and public spaces might look under the proposed framework.

Downtown Core: **Southwest Block**

Downtown Core: **Southeast Block**



Downtown Core: **Northeast Block**



Downtown Core: **Northwest Block**

North Gateway

North Gateway Block

CHAPTER

04 Street Amenities and Wayfinding

Standard Streetscape Layout

Street amenities are features placed between buildings and the street that enhance comfort and usability of the space. These features include street trees, benches, lighting, trash cans, bike racks, murals, planters, and more.

Street amenities directly shape how people experience streets and are especially important within a downtown area. These features influence how people move through, use, and enjoy downtown, often encouraging them to engage with local businesses while also contributing to the downtown character.

This chapter establishes a standard sidewalk layout, evaluates sidewalk quality within the downtown core, inventories existing street amenities, provides guidance for street amenity frequency, and concludes with wayfinding design and placement recommendations.

Within a downtown context, sidewalks have distinct zones that each serve different purposes. These zones provide space for pedestrian movement and various street amenities. The illustration below shows the typical organization of these zones from the building edge to the street.

Category	Frontage Zone	Pedestrian Through Zone	Street Furniture/ Curb Zone	Enhancement / Buffer Zone
NACTO Sidewalk Zones	Extension of the building. Provides space for doors, window shopping, small displays, planters, or seating.	Clear walkway where pedestrians travel. Should be 8-12 ft wide in high-traffic areas.	Primary space for street amenities such as benches, street trees, lighting, bike racks, etc.	Typically used for bicycle paths, landscaping, or additional street amenities.
Blanding Context	Narrow (2-4 ft), often with benches and small displays.	Narrow (5-6 ft).	Decent width (6-10 ft) and amenities within Downtown Core	Not present in Blanding.

Streetscape Quality

The quality of the streetscape varies throughout downtown.
This section provides three categories for evaluating streetscape quality:

BASIC
Continuous sidewalk, grass strip or minimal curb zone, few amenities

ENHANCED
Continuous sidewalk, paved curb zone, frequent street amenities

INCOMPLETE
No sidewalk, no street amenities

Type	Downtown Core	North Gateway	South Gateway
Basic	4,304.4 ft	2,985.1 ft	2,559.3 ft
Enhanced	4,843.7 ft	68.8 ft	0 ft
Incomplete	4,423.9 ft	892.4 ft	546.3 ft

Downtown Core

The Downtown Core encompasses approximately 10 blocks centered on Main Street and Center Street, creating the heart of Blanding's downtown. The area contains the city's most consistent and well-developed sidewalks, although some gaps still exist.

Along US-191, the sidewalk layout has a traditional downtown feel with paved curb zones and many street amenities. Local streets in this area are less developed with few amenities and many lacking sidewalks, curb, and gutter entirely.

MAIN STREET

THE FLOWER SHOP

BLUE SAGE INN & SUITES

CREAMY DELIGHTS

LDS CHURCH

Downtown Core

CENTER STREET

A&W RESTAURANT

HUNTS TRADING POST

DIAMOND STORES

Downtown Core

LOCAL STREETS

100 S (WEST OF MAIN)

100 S (EAST OF MAIN)

200 S

100 E

North and South Gateways

The North and South Gateways frame the downtown and serve as a transition between highway corridor and central business district. These areas have a noticeably more suburban character than the downtown core.

Sidewalks are present along US-191, but the paved curb zone found in the downtown core is replaced by a grass strip or, in some places, no buffer at all between the sidewalk and highway. Street amenities are largely absent. Local streets are less developed with many lacking sidewalk, curb, and gutter entirely.

NORTH GATEWAY

VISITOR CENTER

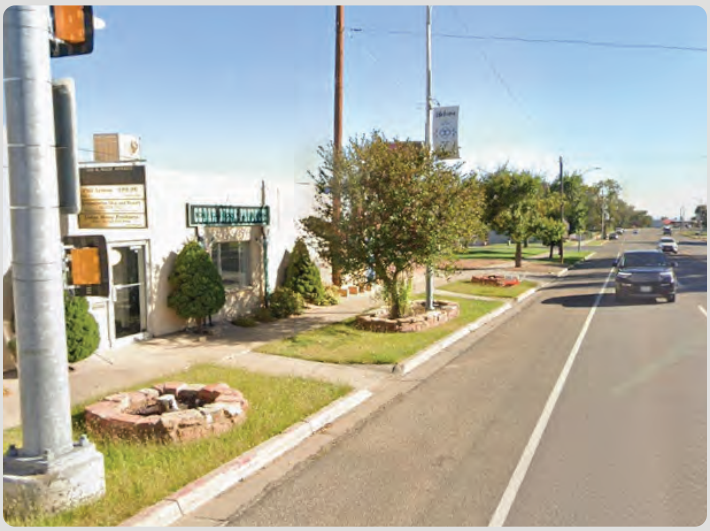
MAVERIK

GRAYSON GENERAL STORE

PATIO DINER

North and South Gateways

SOUTH GATEWAY



CEDAR MESA POTTERY

BLANDING PUBLIC LIBRARY

400 S

500 S

What about curb and gutter?

Curb and gutter are common within downtown environments. They create a clear edge between the street and sidewalk, help manage stormwater, and visually reinforce an urbanized character. They also help organize on-street parking and protect sidewalks and landscaping from vehicle encroachment.

In smaller communities, however, residents often associate the absence of curb and gutter with a more rural or informal aesthetic. Installation can also be costly—typically **$35–$60 per linear foot**, depending on drainage and site conditions—making it a significant investment for local streets.

In Blanding, curb and gutter are **recommended along US-191 and on local streets with active commercial uses**, particularly within the Downtown Core.

Street Amenities Inventory

This assessment of the street amenities reveals an uneven distribution across the downtown. While the core area offers a relatively high concentration of amenities, **Main Street to the south and Center Street to the north lack adequate features** that contribute to a welcoming pedestrian environment. Addressing these gaps as development occurs is critical to creating a consistent downtown experience and ensuring that all areas—not just the core—are attractive, functional, and supportive of community life.

Street Amenities [by type]

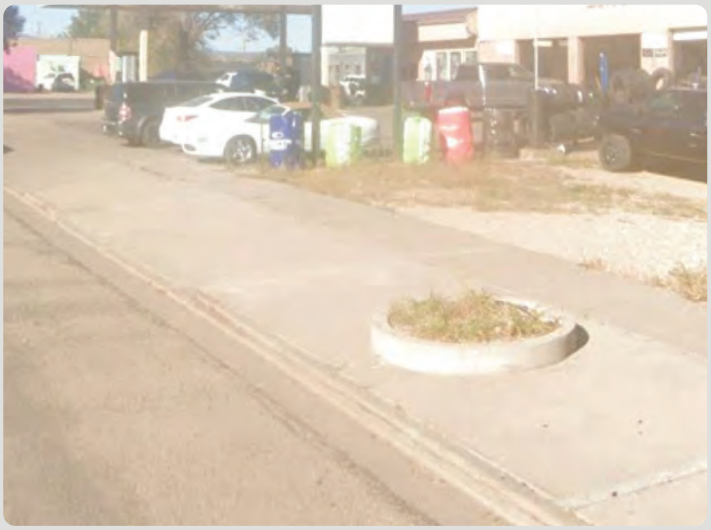
Street Trees

There are currently approximately 286 street trees in downtown Blanding. These are mainly concentrated along the US-191 corridor and in the downtown core.

Street trees provide shade, comfort, and visual appeal while softening wide roadways and creating a more pedestrian-friendly scale. They also offer environmental benefits such as reducing heat, improving air quality, and managing stormwater. Planting more trees would further strengthen walkability and downtown identity.

Successful tree planting depends on pairing water-efficient species with reliable irrigation during establishment. Plan for **$500–$1,200** per tree installed and **$450–$750** in maintenance during the first 3 years. With proper care, **90–95%** survival rate after 5 years. Without irrigation/maintenance, mortality may not exceed 30%.

GAPS



MAIN STREET AND 100 S (CANYONLANDS TIRE): 1 TREE

MAIN STREET AND CENTER STREET (DESERT RIVERS CREDIT UNION): 1 TREE

CENTER STREET AND 100 E (BEARS EARS INN): 3 TREES

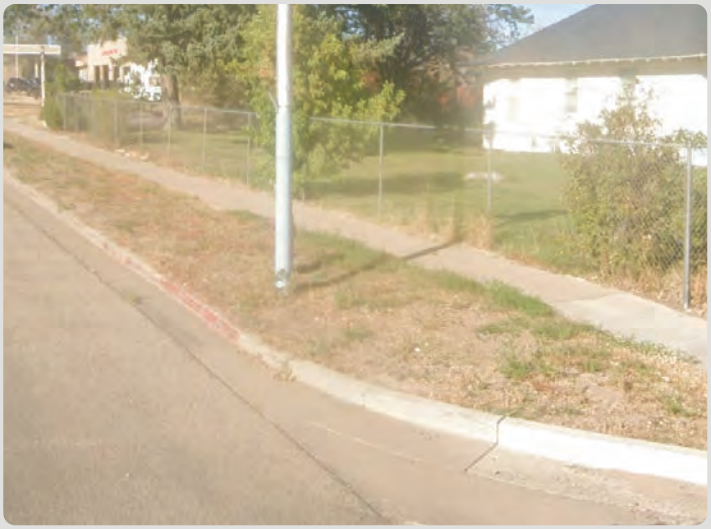
CENTER STREET (HUNTS TRADING POST): 4 TREES

Street Trees

GAPS

MAIN STREET AND 300 S (CEDAR MESA POTTERY): 4 TREES

MAIN STREET AND 200 S (CHURCH PARKING LOT): 8 TREES



MAIN STREET AND 200 S (NORTH-EAST BLOCK): 4 TREES

MAIN STREET (KUNG PAO EXPRESS): 1 TREE

Tree Recommendations:

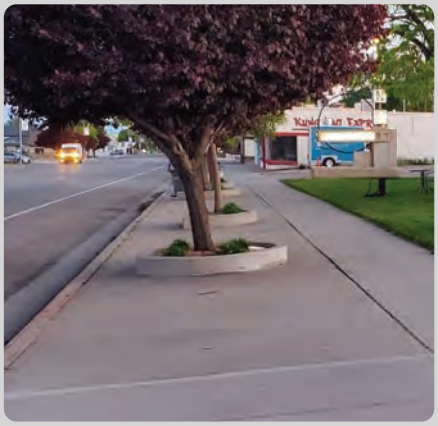
Plant 26 new trees in the street tree gap locations.

SPACE TREES ACCORDING TO MATURE CANOPY SIZE:

Small trees: ~20 ft apart.

Medium trees: ~30 ft apart.

Large canopy trees: ~40 ft apart



Lighting

Lighting in a downtown setting plays an essential role in supporting both vehicle traffic and pedestrian activity. For drivers, effective roadway lighting improves visibility, reduces nighttime crashes, and enhances overall traffic safety. For pedestrians, lighting extends the hours that streets and public spaces feel safe and usable, making sidewalks, crosswalks, and gathering areas more comfortable and inviting.

Beyond safety, well-designed lighting contributes to a welcoming atmosphere, highlights architectural features, and reinforces the character of downtown, strengthening both the social and economic vitality of the area.

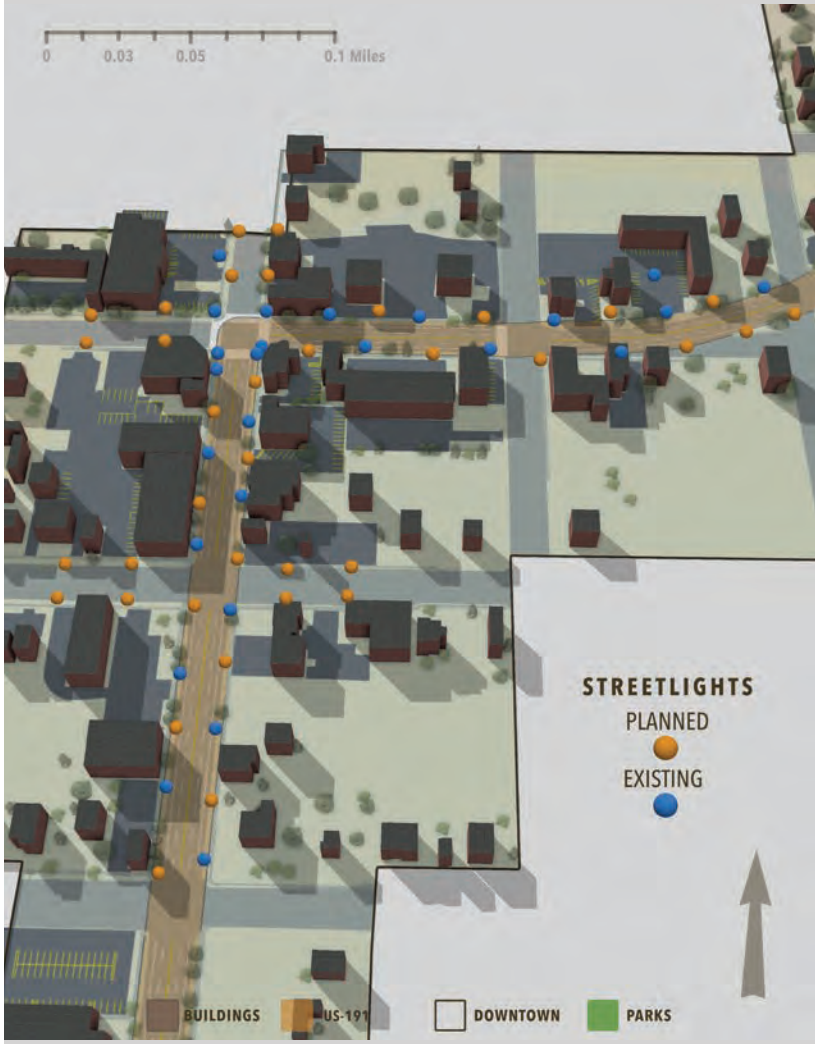
Within downtown Blanding, these tall, utilitarian roadway lights are the primary (and often only) light sources. While they serve their purpose for vehicles traveling through Main Street, they do little to enhance visibility or comfort for people walking on sidewalks, crossing streets, or spending time downtown in the evening.

This reliance on roadway-scale fixtures underscores the need for additional pedestrian-oriented lighting on sidewalks and at crosswalks to create a safer, more inviting downtown environment after dark.

Recommendations:

- Add pedestrian oriented sidewalk lighting to the downtown along Main Street and Center Street (see map)
    - **23 pedestrian oriented lighting fixtures** can be added to the existing roadway-scale light posts 10-14 feet above the sidewalk.
    - **36 pedestrian-scale light posts** may be installed between the existing posts to ensure consistent sidewalk illumination.

Streetlight Map



Seating

Seating is an essential street amenity that encourages people to pause, rest, and spend more time in a downtown environment. Well-placed benches and seating areas support pedestrians of all ages and abilities, provide comfort for shoppers and visitors, and create opportunities for social interaction.

In addition to improving accessibility, seating contributes to placemaking by signaling that downtown is not just a pass-through space, but a destination where people are welcome to gather, linger, and connect with the community.

Most of the seating in Downtown Blanding is concentrated in the core area and near the Visitor Center, leaving other parts of Main Street and Center Street without adequate options. Expanding seating beyond the core would provide resting places for pedestrians throughout downtown, encourage longer visits, and create a more welcoming and people-friendly environment.

Recommendations:

- Encourage local businesses to add outdoor seating areas in front of their establishments.

- Provide additional seating in shared community spaces. The pavilion behind Creamy Delights Ice Cream Shop is a great example of effective public seating. Develop two additional community spaces in the locations below.

SOUTHEAST SIDE OF DESTINATION AWAKE

A&W PARKING LOT AREA

CURRENT EXAMPLES:

Trash Cans

Outdoor, public trash cans play an important role in downtown environments, helping to contain waste and prevent litter in public spaces. Trash cans contribute to an attractive and clean streetscape.

Currently, Downtown Blanding has 21 public trash cans, 10 of which are concentrated in the downtown core area and 11 near the Visitor Center. While this provides good coverage in the heart of downtown, there are notable gaps further south along Main Street and north along US-191. Expanding the number and distribution of trash receptacles in these areas would help maintain a clean, welcoming environment throughout the entire downtown district.

The price of a public-use trash receptacle depends heavily on both its material and design. For example, a lightweight plastic unit similar to the receptacles currently present in downtown Blanding cost approximately $420. In contrast, heavier-duty materials like powder-coated steel or stainless steel receptacles cost around $650.

Recommendations:

- Ensure that there are two public trash cans on each block on Main Street and E Center Street (north of 300 s and west of 200 E). Place trash cans in the curb zone near visible, high trafficked areas such as shops, restaurants, outdoor seating areas, and public buildings.

CURRENT EXAMPLES:

Murals and Placemaking Features

Murals offer a powerful opportunity to celebrate the community's cultural heritage, natural landscapes, and unique identity within the region. Murals can transform blank facades into engaging visual landmarks, making downtown streets more vibrant and walkable. They create points of interest that invite people to pause, explore, and connect with local businesses, while also reflecting the stories and values that define the community.

By integrating murals into the downtown environment, Blanding can strengthen its sense of place, support tourism, and enhance the overall character and vitality of Main Street.

Beyond murals, Blanding's downtown can benefit from a range of placemaking features such as public art, clocks, decorative paving, and other distinctive design elements. These features add identity, create memorable experiences, and help distinguish downtown from surrounding areas.

Recommendations:

- Hire local or Utah based artists to paint murals at 4 facades: Subway, Ace Hardware, Bradford Tire, and Dollar General. Cost of murals can vary based on several factors such as artist experience, size, and materials. Outdoor murals typically cost $35–$100 per square foot, reflecting the extra preparation, materials, and labor required for weather-exposed surfaces.

CENTER STREET MEDIAN CLOCK

HIGHER GROUNDS COFFEE AND SODA

BEARS EARS INN

SAN JUAN THEATER

GAS STATION DINOSAUR SCULPTURE

Opportunity Facades

NORTH GATEWAY

SUBWAY

ACE HARDWARE

BRADFORD TIRE

DOLLAR GENERAL

Bike Racks

Bike parking racks will play an important role in encouraging more biking to and from downtown Blanding by providing secure and convenient places to park. Strategically placed racks near shops, dining, and services reinforce downtown as a bike-friendly destination, reduce car dependency, and strengthen connections between surrounding neighborhoods and the downtown core.

There are **currently no bike racks in downtown Blanding**. U-rack style bicycle parking should be installed at key destinations throughout downtown. These racks will encourage more cycling trips and reinforce downtown as a bike-friendly destination.

When selecting rack designs, be sure that racks provide at least two points of contact with the frame and allow users to easily secure the frame and one wheel with a U-lock. Standard U-racks or similar models are the simplest and cheapest option, about $160 per rack. More artistic rack designs are available but cost significantly more and can compromise functionality.

Recommendations:

- Provide 2 bike racks within the curb zone on each block within the downtown core (see map).
- Install additional bike racks at each priority destination: Visitor Center, Bowling Alley, Pavilion, Centennial Park, South Park, Central Park, Library. (see map).

Street Amenity Recommendations

Feature	Recommended Frequency	# existing	# proposed	Cost Description	Cost Estimate
Street trees	Every 30-40 ft	286	26	Installation: $500-$1,200 per tree Maintenance (3 years): $450-$750 per tree	$24,700-$50,700
Lighting	Pedestrian lighting every 25 ft.	64	23 fixtures. 36 fixtures w/ new posts.	Fixtures (on existing posts): $600-$1,500 ea. Fixtures w/ new posts: $3,200-$6,000 ea.	$13,000- $55,000
Seating	At least 2 on each block, plus 2 extra at key destinations	22	11	$420-$650 per can	$4,620-$7,150
Placemaking Features	n/a	5	4	$35-$100 per sq. ft.	n/a
Bike Racks	At least 2 on each block, plus extra at key destinations	0	40	$160 per U-rack	$7,840
Totals	**n/a**	**441**	**181**	**n/a**	**$179,160-$371,190**

Wayfinding

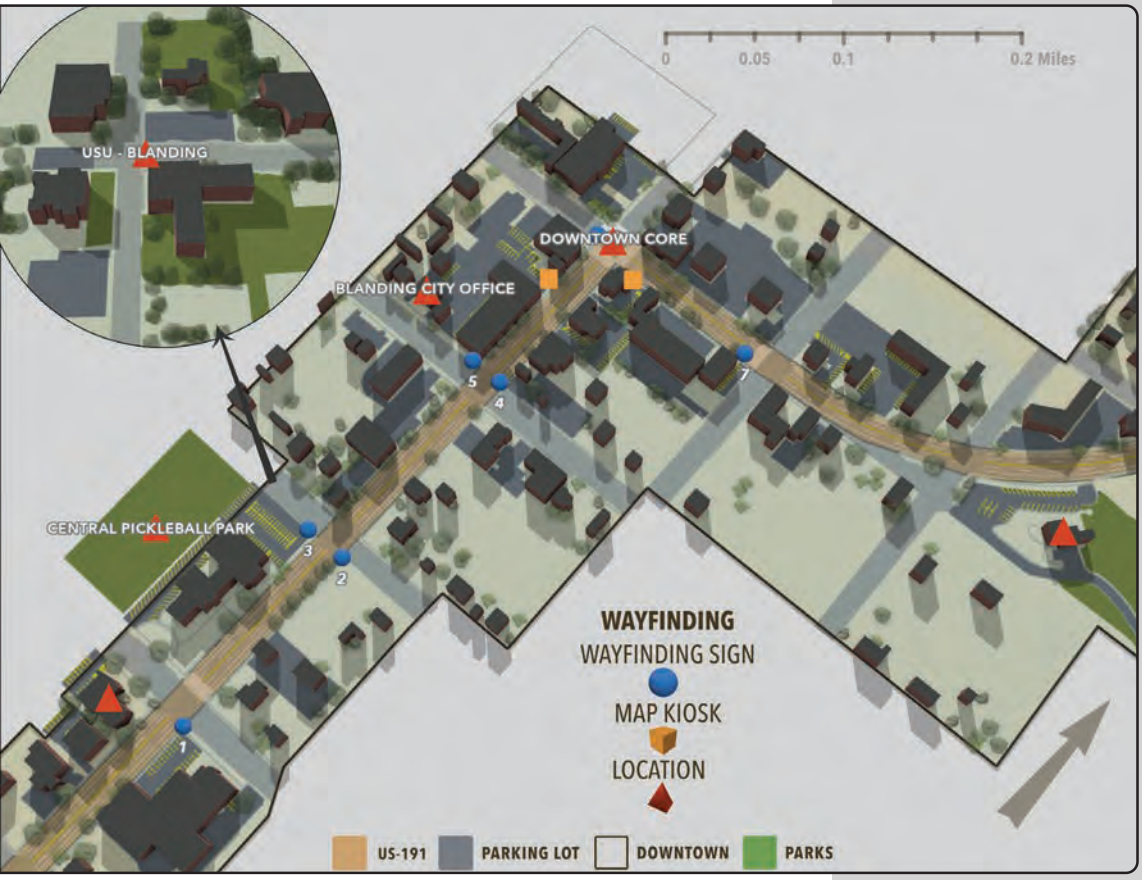
Wayfinding is a critical component of a successful downtown environment, helping residents and visitors navigate streets, destinations, and public spaces with ease. Clear, well-placed signage reduces confusion, improves safety, and encourages people to explore more of the downtown area by making walking routes intuitive and accessible.

In a pedestrian-oriented context, wayfinding supports walkability by guiding people to shops, dining, cultural sites, and public facilities, ultimately extending the amount of time and activity that occurs within the district.

Beyond navigation, wayfinding also serves as a tool for downtown branding. Consistent design elements—such as color, typography, and symbols—reinforce a unified identity for downtown and create a stronger sense of place. In Blanding, pedestrian-focused wayfinding can highlight community destinations while simultaneously contributing to a recognizable downtown brand, strengthening both function and character.

Wayfinding Sign Recommendations

Sign Type	Proposed	Cost Description	Cost Estimate
Decision Sign	7	Sign on existing pole = $450 Sign and new pole = $1,120	$7,840
Map Kiosk	2	Kiosk: $3,000-$8,000 Installation/labor: $250-$1,000	$6,500-$18,000
Total:			**$14,340-$25,840**



This plan proposes two wayfinding sign types within the downtown:

- **DECISION SIGNS:** Placed near intersections, these provide up to three destination options with distances in miles and minutes, listed in order of proximity and direction.
- **MAP KIOSKS:** Freestanding information display that includes a map of downtown highlighting key landmarks, businesses, public amenities, and walking routes.

Wayfinding Sign Content

Sign #	Orientation	Arrow	Destination	Distance
1a	North-facing	Right	Blanding Public Library	200 ft.
1b	South-facing	Straight	Blanding Public Library	200 ft.
		Left	Central Pickleball Park	500 ft.
		Left	Downtown Core	0.25 mi.
2a	North-facing	Straight	Central Park	500 ft.
		Right	Blanding Public Library	700 ft.
		Right	USU - Blanding	0.65 mi.
2b	South-facing	Straight	Central Park	500 ft.
		Left	Downtown Core	800 ft.
		Left	USU - Blanding	0.65 mi.
3a	North-facing	Straight	Central Park	400 ft.
		Right	Blanding Public Library	700 ft
		Right	USU - Blanding	0.65 mi.
3b	South-facing	Straight	Central Park	400 ft.
		Left	Downtown Core	800 ft.
		Left	USU - Blanding	0.65 mi.
4a	North-facing	Right	Blanding City Office	300 ft.
		Straight	Central Park	1000 ft.
		Straight	Blanding Public Library	0.25 mi.
4b	South-facing	Straight	Downtown Core	0 ft.
		Straight	Blanding City Office	300 ft.
		Left	Blanding Visitor's Center	0.35 mi.
5a	North-facing	Right	Blanding City Office	250 ft.
		Straight	Central Park	1000 ft.
		Straight	Blanding Public Library	0.25 mi.
5b	South-facing	Straight	Downtown Core	0 ft.
		Straight	Blanding Visitor's Center	0.35 mi.
		Left	Blanding City Office	250 ft.
6a	West-facing	Right	Downtown Core	0 ft.
		Right	Central Park	0.25 mi.
		Straight	Blanding Visitor's Center	0.25 mi.
6b	East-facing	Left	Downtown Core	0 ft.
		Left	Blanding City Office	700 ft.
		Left	Central Park	0.25 mi.
7a	West-facing	Straight	Blanding Visitor's Center	900 ft.
7b	East-facing	Straight	Downtown Core	500 ft.
		Straight	Blanding City Office	0.25 mi
		Straight	Central Park	0.35 mi.

CHAPTER

05 Branding and Marketing

Regional Context

As the commercial core and a corridor for regional traffic, downtown Blanding is the place where visitors often form their first impression of the city. Branding and marketing can help shape that impression, tell Blanding's story, and attract more residents and visitors to the community.

A clear and consistent brand helps visitors understand what makes Blanding special, while strategic marketing ensures that message reaches the right audience. Branding also supports many of the physical improvements identified in this plan.

With consistent branding, streetscape features and wayfinding can contribute to a unified visual identity and downtown experience — one that feels intentional, memorable, and worth returning to.

This chapter provides a framework for how Blanding can strengthen its identity and share it more effectively.

Tourism is a major part of the economy in Southeastern Utah. Within Utah's Four Corners region, Blanding is surrounded by world-class outdoor recreation areas and sites of deep cultural and historical importance.

Regional Attractions

- Bears Ears National Monument
- Four Corners National Monument
- Hovenweep National Monument
- Natural Bridges National Monument
- Monument Valley
- Canyonlands National Park

Local Attractions

- Edge of the Cedars State Park
- The Dinosaur Museum
- Five Kiva Pueblo Ruins
- Utah State University - Blanding

US-191 connects these destinations and brings thousands of travelers directly through Blanding each year. By positioning the downtown as a welcoming basecamp worth visiting, the city can convert more of this pass-through traffic into meaningful visits and economic activity.

THE DINOSAUR MUSEUM

EDGE OF THE CEDARS STATE PARK

FIVE KIVA PUEBLO RUINS

USU BLANDING

What is Blanding's Brand?

Blanding's long-time motto, "Base Camp to Adventure," reflects the city's central location amid the remarkable landscapes of southeastern Utah. However, during this plan's community workshop, many residents expressed uncertainty about the motto and felt it did not fully capture the city's character. It's also very similar to Moab's motto "The Adventure Begins." The city itself seems to be moving away from the phrase, leaving an opportunity to reexamine Blanding's brand.

A brand is more than a logo or tagline, it's a story the community tells about itself and the experience it offers to others. Developing this brand should be a community-led process with residents, business owners, and local partners. This plan outlines a few themes that can guide the process.

Potential brand themes:

- **GATEWAY TO THE FOUR CORNERS** - Emphasize Blanding's location and easy access to surrounding monuments and trails within the Four Corners region.
- **QUIET ADVENTURES** - Position Blanding as a relaxed alternative to busier recreation destinations like Moab, offering the same access to outdoor adventure with a quieter, more authentic small-town setting.
- **ANCIENT HERITAGE AND CULTURE** - Celebrate Blanding's proximity to ancient archaeological and cultural sites while uplifting present-day Native voices.
- **DARK SKIES AND QUIET NIGHTS** - Highlight the area's unique night-sky experiences and tranquil small-town atmosphere.
- **LOCAL CRAFTSMANSHIP** - Showcase Blanding's locally owned shops and artisans that offer one-of-a-kind goods and small-town hospitality.

Once developed, this brand should be reflected in the visual identity within downtown. Consistency in tone and design helps visitors recognize Blanding's story. Consider incorporating brand colors, font, and iconography across wayfinding signs, maps, gateway monuments, streetlight banners, murals, and digital materials.

Priority Audiences

Effective marketing starts with understanding your audience. Different types of visitors interact with the city differently. Some may be passing through on their way to nearby destinations, while others may plan their trip around local destinations.

- **REGIONAL TRAVELERS** - Many visitors pass through Blanding along US-191 traveling between Moab, Monument Valley, Lake Powell, and Mesa Verde. Targeting these travelers with clear signage and compelling visuals can help convert pass-through traffic into short visits for dining, shopping, and exploration.

- **OUTDOOR RECREATION TRAVELERS** - Visitors drawn to nearby national monuments and recreation sites often look for a comfortable basecamp. Downtown Blanding can appeal to this group with lodging, restaurants, and small-town amenities that combine convenience with the calm and authenticity missing from busier gateway communities like Moab.

- **CULTURAL AND HERITAGE TRAVELERS** - Some visitors come specifically for the region's deep cultural and archaeological significance. These travelers tend to stay longer, spend more locally, and value opportunities for learning. Partnerships with museums, Tribal organizations, and other institutions can help Blanding become known as a cultural center for the region.

- **SAN JUAN COUNTY RESIDENTS** - Residents from nearby communities are a consistent and dependable audience. Consider marketing that encourages locals to visit downtown for events, shopping, and dining options only available in Blanding.

Marketing Tools and Strategies

Marketing strategies help visitors discover downtown Blanding before they arrive and experience it more fully once they are here. A consistent approach—across signage, print materials, and digital platforms—ensures that the downtown's identity feels connected and recognizable in every setting.
Whether someone is walking along Main Street, searching online, or driving through town, they should encounter the same clear message and visual character that defines Blanding's brand.

- **DIGITAL PRESENCE** - Create a Visit Downtown Blanding webpage that highlights dining, lodging, shopping, events, and nearby attractions. Consider including short themed itineraries such as One Day in Blanding, Dark Sky Evenings, or Cultural Explorer. Encourage local businesses to maintain accurate Google Business Profiles with up-to-date hours, photos, and contact information.

- **SOCIAL MEDIA** - Establish consistent branding on city social media platforms. Coordinate with local businesses and regional groups to increase visibility. Encourage visitors to share their own photos and experiences.

- **EVENTS** - Organize seasonal events that give residents and visitors reason to return downtown throughout the year. This might include local markets, art walks, parades, festivals, street fairs, holiday events, and more.

- **VISITOR INFORMATION** - Update maps, brochures, and other materials that highlight downtown businesses, amenities, and points of interest. Ensure these materials use consistent branding and messaging. Distribute these materials digitally and in print at the visitor center, hotels, and downtown shops.

- **DOWNTOWN SIGNS** - Incorporate branding into physical elements of the downtown including street banners, wayfinding signs, map kiosks, and shop storefronts. Consistent design reinforced the downtown identity.

Partnerships

Successful branding and marketing efforts depend on close coordination between the city, local businesses, community groups, tribal partners, and regional agencies. Each partner plays a distinct role in how Blanding presents itself to residents and visitors, ensuring that marketing efforts are authentic and consistent.

- **CITY LEADERSHIP** - City officials and staff should take the lead in coordinating branding and marketing efforts, maintaining visual standards, and ensuring consistency across signage, digital media, and printed materials. The city can help align marketing initiatives with community goals like downtown revitalization, infrastructure improvements, and economic development.

- **COMMUNITY GROUPS AND VOLUNTEERS** - Nonprofits groups, the local rotary club, schools, and residents can support the city through maintaining the downtown's appearance, building or funding new projects, hosting events, sharing stories about the community, preparing and distributing marketing materials, and welcoming visitors.

- **LOCAL BUSINESSES** - Local businesses are the heart of downtown's identity and should be directly involved in developing and applying the downtown brand. The Blanding Chamber of Commerce can serve as a bridge between the city and businesses owners — organizing promotions, coordinating events, and helping merchants implement marketing strategies.

- **TRIBAL PARTNERS** - If Blanding decides to include cultural references as part of its branding and marketing, it is essential to collaborate with Tribal partners throughout the process. Working closely with Indigenous communities will ensure that cultural stories and imagery are accurate, respectful, and appropriate for public use. Collaboration also opens the door to shared programming that creates a deeper, more meaningful experience for visitors and residents.

- **REGIONAL AND STATE ENTITIES** - San Juan County and the Utah Office of Tourism both offer valuable expertise and promotional support. Collaboration with these agencies can extend the city's visibility.

Inspiration from Utah Communities

Many small cities across Utah have successfully used branding and marketing to strengthen their local identity and attract visitors. These examples show how creative storytelling, consistent messaging, and well-timed events can help communities stand out within Utah's competitive tourism landscape.

Moab - Discover Moab

Moab is a small city of about 5,000 residents in Eastern Utah. Despite its small size, Moab has built one of Utah's most recognizable brands through deliberate, year-round marketing under the Discover Moab banner.

A key part of Moab's success is its strategy to space major events throughout the year, ensuring there is always something drawing people to the city. These create a near-continuous calendar of activity that fills hotel rooms, keeps restaurants and shops busy, and reinforces Moab's image as a lively and adventurous place no matter the season. Signature events include:

- **MOAB MUSIC FESTIVAL**
- **MOAB CENTURY TOUR**
- **RED ROCK ARTS FESTIVAL**
- **ARTS & AGRICULTURE MARKET**
- **CASTLE VALLEY GOURD FESTIVAL**
- **RED CANYON POW WOW**
- **MOAB JEEP JAMBOREE**
- **MOAB FOLK FESTIVAL**

Moab's approach demonstrates how consistent branding and programming can transform a small city into a regional destination. The Discover Moab platform ties together marketing, storytelling, and event promotion under a unified identity—making it easy for visitors to find information, plan their trips, and experience the community year-round.

Scandinavian Heritage Festival (Ephraim)

Ephraim City is a small college town (home of Snow College) in Central Utah with a population of about 6,000 residents.

The city hosts a Scandinavian Heritage Festival each year on Memorial Day weekend. This two-day celebration fills downtown streets and the Snow College campus with parades, heritage demonstrations, live performances, food and craft vendors, and family activities. This is one of central Utah's largest annual events, drawing thousands of visitors.

By centering the event on its unique Scandinavian heritage, Ephraim has turned local culture into a lasting brand with huge economic benefits. The partnership between the city and Snow College strengthens this effort by combining venues, volunteers, and marketing reach.

Escalante Canyons Art Festival (Escalante)

Escalante is a small gateway town in Southern Utah along Scenic Byway 12 with about 800 residents.

Each September, it hosts the Escalante Canyons Art Festival—a week long celebration of art and landscape with painting competitions, workshops, live music, art sales, and guided walks. Founded in 2003 by local nonprofits, the festival has grown into a major regional event that draws artists and visitors from across the West.

The festival ties art, nature, and community together while boosting the local economy and turning downtown into a temporary outdoor gallery. Its consistent timing, strong partnerships, and deep connection to the landscape have helped Escalante build a distinctive identity that reaches far beyond its size.

Melon Days (Green River)

Green River is a small agricultural community along I-70 in Eastern Utah with a population of roughly 900 residents. Each September, the city celebrates Melon Days, a harvest-season festival with a parade, melon tasting, vendors, family activities, and community entertainment in the town's central park. It has been held for more than a century, making it one of Utah's oldest continuously running festivals.

The festival has become central to Green River's identity and its tourism marketing. By centering local agriculture as the heart of the celebration, the city has created a distinctive and authentic brand that sets it apart from nearby recreation destinations. Images of stacked melons, farm stands, and community gatherings now symbolize Green River as clearly as its surrounding red rock landscape.

Balloons & Tunes Roundup (Kanab)

Kanab is a gateway community with about 5,000 residents in southern Utah, located between Zions National Park and the Grand Canyon National Park.

During President's Day weekend each February, Kanab hosts the Balloons & Tunes Roundup, a multi-day festival featuring early-morning hot-air balloon launches, an evening balloon glow on downtown streets, live music, food vendors, and family activities. The event brings dozens of balloon teams to town, turning Kanab's main corridors into a colorful, walkable showcase and drawing spectators from across the region during an otherwise quiet season.

Balloons & Tunes has become a signature element of Kanab's brand. Consistent timing, promotion, and strong partner coordination have helped Kanab turn a unique winter spectacle into a reliable driver of visitation and downtown spending during the off-season.

Branding and Marketing Recommendations

The following actions provide a starting point for Blanding to strengthen its brand identity and work towards a coordinated marketing strategy for downtown.

Category	Action
Brand Development	• Conduct community workshops or surveys to develop a brand with residents and stakeholders.
	• Prepare a downtown brand guide for use by the city, businesses, and partners.
Digital Tools	• Update the Visit Blanding webpage (or launch a new site) highlighting downtown attractions, dining, lodging, events, and itineraries.
	• Work with businesses to update Google profiles with accurate hours, photos, locations, and downtown branding.
	• Maintain consistent information across city, chamber, and tourism websites about Blanding.
	• Develop social media content highlighting attractions with downtown Blanding.
Physical Tools	• Update visitor materials (maps, brochures, etc) with consistent branding and distribute locally.
	• Apply brand colors and imagery to street banners, gateway signs, murals, and wayfinding signs throughout the downtown.
	• Work with businesses to include downtown branding and messaging on storefront signs where appropriate.
Events	• Establish seasonal events that celebrate Blanding's character and attract repeat visitors.
Partnerships	• Collaborate with businesses and community groups to align strategies and ensure consistent branding and messaging.
	• Engage with Tribal partners as needed when using cultural storytelling and imagery.
	• Align marketing with San Juan County and the Utah Office of Tourism campaigns to expand marketing reach.

CHAPTER

06 Implementation Plan

Next Steps

This final chapter outlines implementation strategies for Blanding City to follow including immediate next steps, a framework for prioritizing and phasing projects, tools to support business growth, additional resources, and funding strategies.

Next Steps

- **PLAN ADOPTION** - This plan and its associated zoning language should be formally adopted by the Blanding Planning Commission and City Council. Adoption will integrate the plan into city policy, establish new zoning standards, and signal a commitment to revitalizing downtown through coordinated public and private investment.

- **DOWNTOWN ADVISORY COMMITTEE** - Consider establishing an advisory committee to oversee implementation of this plan. This group will follow through on implementation actions, coordinate with partners, prioritize projects, resolve issues, and monitor progress. The group may include representatives from the planning commission, city council, city staff, UDOT, the Blanding Chamber of Commerce, and other local groups.

- **BUSINESS AND PROPERTY OWNER OUTREACH** - Downtown improvements will depend on strong partnerships with local businesses and property owners. The city should share this plan with them, promote available incentives or grants, and encourage property improvements. This is especially important for abandoned properties within the downtown core.

- **ENGINEERING AND DESIGN** - While this plan provides high-level recommendations for street improvements and amenities, additional planning and design work may be required before projects are construction ready. This will refine alignments, confirm feasibility, produce more accurate cost estimates, and improve eligibility for grant funding.

- **PARTNER COORDINATION** - Many recommendations in this plan involve coordination with partners. The City should work closely with UDOT to plan and implement improvements on US-191. Regional partners including San Juan County and the Utah Office of Tourism will also be helpful to leverage resources and align efforts across agencies.

Implementation Timeline

This section provides a general timeline for implementing recommendations, broken down into short-, medium-, and long-term actions. This timeline is intended to be flexible depending on funding, partnerships, permitting, and site-specific conditions.

Time Frame	Category	Action
Short-Term (0-2 years)	**Planning**	• Establish an Downtown Advisory Committee.
		• Develop an Active Transportation Plan and Safe Routes to School Plan.
		• Establish Downtown Improvement Grant program.
		• Identify and apply for grants to support plan implementation.
		• Work with UDOT to study US-191 improvement options, including 4-to-3 lane road diet, crossing improvements, new crossings, and long-term rerouting of US-191 away from downtown.
	Land Use	• Adopt Downtown District Code and Downtown District Design Guidelines.
		• Encourage development to fill/replace abandoned businesses.
	Transportation	• Construct new sidewalks to fill gaps within the downtown (US-191 and local streets).
		• Mark local street crossings (x16)
		• Add lane striping and mark parking spaces on local streets with high commercial traffic.
		• Engage with Tribal partners as needed when using cultural storytelling and imagery.
		• Encourage shared parking agreements between businesses.
	Street Amenities	• Work with local partners to build new community spaces with pavilions and seating near A&W and Destination Awake.
		• Plant 26 new trees to fill street tree gaps.
		• Install 11 new trash cans to ensure at least 2 per block.
		• Paint new murals at 4 locations.
		• Install 49 bike racks to ensure at least 2 on each block, plus 2 extra at key locations.
		• Work with UDOT to install up to 175 pedestrian-oriented lights within the downtown core.
	Branding	• Develop a community brand with residents and stakeholders.
		• Prepare a downtown brand guide for the city, businesses, and partners.
		• Update the Visit Blanding webpage.
		• Work with businesses to update Google profiles and maintain consistent information online.

Time Frame	Category	Action
Medium-Term (3-5 years)	Transportation	• Convert US-191 from 4 lanes to 3 lanes.
		• Improve US-191 ped crossings (x6) and install new crossings (x5).
		• Work with businesses to upgrade parking lots with midblock walkways, landscaping, shade trees, and lighting as needed.
	Land Use	• Work with property owners to improve older and nonconforming downtown properties.
		• Encourage new development to fill street frontage gaps and large parking lots.
	Branding	• Update visitor materials with consistent branding and messaging.
		• Apply branding/messaging to street banners, gateway signs, murals, and wayfinding signs.
		• Establish seasonal events to attract repeat visitors.

Time Frame	Category	Action
Long-Term (5-10 years)	Planning	• Update this plan.

Business Development Strategies

Downtown improvements outlined in this plan — such as improved street design, new street amenities, and coordinated marketing — will directly support businesses and make downtown a more attractive place to visit, shop, and invest. This section provides some additional actions the City can take to further support business growth.

- **DOWNTOWN IMPROVEMENT GRANTS**
  Establish a city grant program to support property and business improvements within the downtown area. The program could provide matching funds (e.g. 50% match) for projects such as façade upgrades, new signage, lighting, landscaping, and interior renovations that enhance the customer experience. These small, competitive grants help reduce financial barriers for businesses while encouraging investment.

- **STREAMLINED PERMITTING**
  Permitting and review processes can be a major barrier for small businesses. The City should evaluate its current procedures and look for ways to reduce unnecessary delays or costs. Options include consolidating applications, providing pre-approved designs, and offering pre-application meetings to help new businesses understand requirements before they invest.

- **BUSINESS TRAINING AND TECHNICAL ASSISTANCE**
  Partner with the Blanding Chamber of Commerce or other regional partners to host period workshops and/or publish educational materials for downtown business owners. Topics may include marketing, customer service, financial management, permitting, online sales, and more.

- **HOUSING DEVELOPMENT**
  Encouraging new housing downtown and throughout Blanding will help sustain local businesses by increasing the number of year-round residents and potential customers. The City should support mixed-use development within the downtown core and review zoning to ensure housing is permitted and feasible in appropriate areas.

Additional Resources

- **UTAH MAIN STREET PROGRAM**
  A statewide initiative that helps communities strengthen their downtowns through place-based economic development. The program provides training, technical assistance, and funding opportunities for communities.

- **GATEWAY COMMUNITY ONLINE TOOLKIT**
  This toolkit offers case studies, model ordinances, and planning resources tailored to gateway communities near public lands and recreation areas. It can help Blanding address challenges related to tourism, housing, and sustainable economic growth.

- **MODEL LAND USE ORDINANCE LIBRARY**
  A collection of adaptable model ordinances that local governments can use as templates for zoning and development standards. Examples include dark-sky lighting, water-efficient landscaping, and hazard-resilient development.

- **LOCAL GOVERNMENT ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT TOOLBOX**
  Developed by the American Planning Association and state partners, this resource provides strategies for small communities to strengthen their local economies. It includes guidance on business attraction, job creation, and long-term economic planning.

- **ORR RURAL ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT TOOLKIT**
  Offers practical strategies from rural communities across the country for growing outdoor recreation economies. The toolkit can help Blanding leverage its proximity to public lands and outdoor destinations to support local businesses.

- **RCAC ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT RESOURCES PORTAL**
  Provides technical assistance and funding resources for rural communities in the western U.S. RCAC can help Blanding pursue local business development projects, build entrepreneurial support networks, and attract new investment.

Funding Strategies

This plan identifies approximately $1.1 to $1.3 million in recommended downtown improvements, primarily for street infrastructure upgrades and new street amenities. Zoning and policy changes recommended in this plan do not have direct financial costs. Cost estimates for several recommendations (such as the Downtown Improvement Grant program or buildout of the midblock walkway network) are not included in this plan.

While these investments may be led by the City, **a large share of the total cost will be funded in partnership** with other governments agencies, local groups, and property owners. Strategic cost sharing is essential to implementing this plan.

Summary of Proposed Costs

Improvement Category	Cost Estimate
Transportation	$905,200
Land Use	No cost
Street Amenities	$179,160 - $371,190
Wayfinding	$14,340 - $25,840
Branding & Marketing	Not calculated
Total	**$1.099 to $1.302 million**

City Funding

Blanding City's annual expenses (excluding business-type activities) were $2.95 million in 2023 and $2.61 million in 2022. As downtown improvements advance, the City should determine how to incorporate priority projects into its annual budget and capital improvement planning process.

Cost Sharing With Partner

- **UTAH DEPARTMENT OF TRANSPORTATION**
  UDOT owns and maintains the US-191 right-of-way including Main Street and Center Street through downtown. The City should work closely with UDOT to coordinate and jointly fund improvements within this corridor.

- **BUSINESSES AND PROPERTY OWNERS**
  Current and future businesses will play a leading role in improving private properties and frontages. The City can support their investments by ensuring compliance with downtown design standards or through direct funding such as the Downtown improvement Grant program.

- **CHAMBER OF COMMERCE**
  The Blanding Chamber of Commerce can help promote downtown businesses, coordinate events, and serve as a bridge between the City and the private sector to align marketing, signage, and event programming.

- **SAN JUAN COUNTY**
  The County may be a valuable partner for projects that support regional tourism, economic development, and transportation safety. Coordination could include cost sharing for signage, trail connections, or public space enhancements that benefit both residents and visitors.

- **USU BLANDING**
  The campus can be a valuable partner for community events, downtown art installations, or student-led design and business projects that contribute to activation efforts.

Grants & Private Partnerships

- **BLANDING ROTARY CLUB**
  The local rotary club has supported community projects in the past, such as the pavilion behind Creamy Delights. They may continue to support projects such as new pavilions, murals, or landscaping improvements.

- **LOCAL SERVICE GROUPS**
  Groups such as civic clubs, schools, and faith-based organizations can provide volunteer labor, materials, or donations for small public projects, events, and clean-up efforts

- **CORPORATE SPONSORSHIPS**
  Local and regional businesses may be interested in sponsoring amenities, events, or beautification projects. Sponsorship opportunities could include benches, bike racks, planters, or event partnerships that promote both community pride and business visibility.

- **FOUNDATIONS**
  Foundations and nonprofits (such as the Eccles Foundation) often support rural vitality, tourism, and revitalization projects.

- **STATE & FEDERAL GRANTS**
  Many government agencies can help fund community and economic development projects. The Utah Funding Opportunities Portal provides a comprehensive list of these opportunities. Here are some grants that are especially relevant:

  - Utah Main Street Program
  - Utah Office of Tourism - Cooperative Marketing Grant
  - Utah Outdoor Recreation Grant
  - Utah Economic Assistance Grant
  - Community Development Block Grant (CDBG)
  - Transportation Alternatives (TA) and Active Transportation Improvement Infrastructure Investment Program (ATIIP) funding
  - USDOT Safe Streets for All (SS4A) Grant
  - USDOT RAISE/BUILD Grant

Appendix

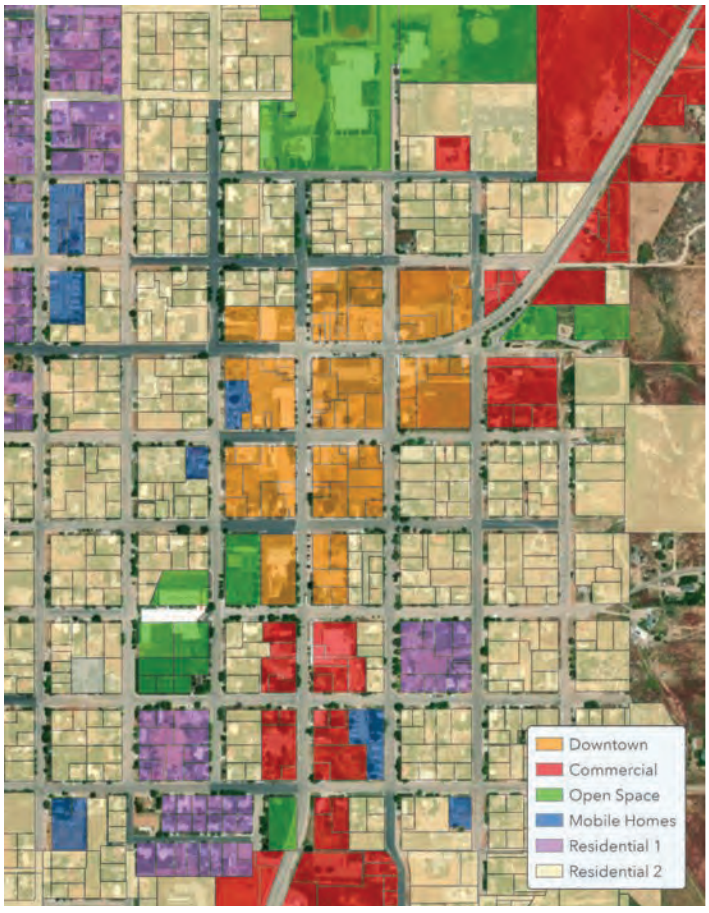
A Downtown District Zoning Code

10.4.1 Districts Established

In order to carry out the provisions of this title, the city is hereby divided into the following basic zoning districts:

R-1	Residential
R-2	Residential
MH	Mobile Home
R-1A	Agricultural Residential
C	Commercial
D	Downtown
I	Industrial
O	Open Space

10.4.2 Zoning District Map



10.5B.4 Home Occupations

C. The total area used for such purposes may not exceed twenty five percent (25%) of the total floor area of the user's dwelling unit; and

H. A home occupation must provide adequate off street parking to accommodate all needs created by the home occupation

   a. Within the D Downtown District, parking requirements shall be determined according to section 10-6B-7 of this title.

   b. Within all other districts, parking requirements shall be determined according to section 10-6A-7 of this title.

10.6B D Downtown District

(redline changes compared to C commercial district code)

10.6B.1 Purpose

The D Downtown District is established to promote a vibrant, walkable city center that serves as the commercial, cultural, and civic heart of Blanding. This district is intended to encourage a mix of retail, dining, housing, office, and community uses in a compact, pedestrian-oriented environment.

Notes:

1. See section 10-12-5 of this title for sign regulations in this district.

10.6B.2 Permitted Uses

The following uses shall be permitted, subject to requirements set forth in this title. Any use not specifically listed shall be prohibited.

Notes:

A. Automobile repair shops.
B. Art studios and galleries
C. Bakeries.
D. Banks.
E. Barber and beauty shops.
F. Blacksmith shops.
G. Cabinet making and carpentry shops.
H. Cleaning establishments.
I. Churches.
J. Clothing stores.
K. Drug stores.
L. Florists.
M. Grocery stores.
N. Hardware stores.
O. Hotels, motels, and inns
P. Laundries.
Q. Libraries
R. Machine shops.
S. Meat stores.
T. Office, studios, and clinics.
U. Personal service shops.
V. Places of amusement or recreation.
W. Places serving food or beverages.
X. Plumbing shops.
Y. Printing and publishing establishments.
Z. Public facilities or utilities.
AA. Sporting goods stores.
BB. Theaters.
CC. Residential uses above the ground floor of a nonresidential
DD. structure.
EE. Veterinary establishments.

10.6B.3 Accessory Uses

Any use which complies with all of the following conditions may be operated as an accessory use:

10.6B.1 Purpose

A. Is clearly incidental and customary to and commonly associated with the operation of the permitted use; and

B. Is operated under the same ownership and on the same zone lot as the permitted use; and

C. Does not include structures or structural features inconsistent with the permitted use; and

D. Does not include structures or structural features inconsistent with the pedestrian-oriented character of the district; and

E. Does not include a floor area of over fifty percent (50%) of the floor area of the permitted use.

10.6B.4 Home Occupations

Home occupations may be permitted within residential units located in the D Downtown District, subject to the same restrictions as set forth in section 10-5B-4 of this title.

10.6B.5 Conditional Uses

The following may be allowed as conditional uses:

A. Historic Buildings. Historic buildings may be used for offices and accessory commercial uses and/or limited retail businesses, subject to the same restrictions as set forth in section 10-5A-5 of this title, R-1 districts.

B. Auto-Oriented Businesses. Automobile sales, used car sales, gas stations, and other auto-oriented businesses may be allowed as conditional uses, subject to Planning Commission review to ensure site design, access, and appearance are compatible with the intent and character of the downtown district.

10.6B.6 Area, Width, Setback And Height Regulations

The following may be allowed as conditional uses:

A. Minimum lot area: None. However, a zone lot must be designated and maintained for each structure containing a permitted use.

B. Minimum lot width: None.

C. Front setback for structures:

a. The front setback shall be between zero feet (0') and five feet (5'), measured from the inside edge of the existing or planned sidewalk.

b. Up to thirty percent (30%) of the building frontage may be recessed up to fifteen feet (15') to allow for pedestrian-oriented spaces such as outdoor dining, seating areas, plazas, or courtyards. See landscaping requirements, chapter 14 of this title.

c. Awnings, balconies, canopies, and other architectural features may project into the setback or beyond the build-to line, provided they do not obstruct pedestrian movement or conflict with street amenities such as trees, lighting, or signage.

D. Minimum rear setback for structures:

a. No minimum rear setback is required.

b. Where a rear lot line abuts a residential district, the minimum rear setback shall be twenty feet (20').

c. Parking areas, when provided, shall be located at the rear of buildings and accessed from side streets or shared driveway access where feasible. See off-street parking and loading requirements, section 10-6B-7 of this title.

E. Minimum side setback for structures:

a. No minimum side setback is required.

b. Where a side lot line abuts a residential district, the minimum side setback shall be twenty feet (20').

c. Where a side setback is provided, the space shall be used for a midblock walkway, shared driveway access to rear parking, or a pedestrian-oriented space such as outdoor dining, seating areas, plazas, or courtyards. See landscaping requirements, chapter 14 of this title.

F. Maximum building height: Fifty feet (50').

G. Lot coverage:

a. Structures containing permitted uses and their accessory uses may cover up to one hundred percent (100%) of the total lot area.

b. Buildings and pedestrian-oriented spaces shall cover at least seventy percent (70%) of the lot frontage along the primary street, measured at the build-to line. See front setback requirements above.

H. Building Orientation:

a. Primary entrances shall be oriented toward the primary street frontage.

b. Secondary entrances may be provided on side or rear facades. Secondary entrances are encouraged where parking areas, secondary streets, midblock walkway, and pedestrian-oriented spaces are located at the side or rear of a building.

c. Primary and secondary entrances shall connect directly to public sidewalk or pedestrian-oriented spaces such as outdoor dining, seating areas, plazas, or courtyards.

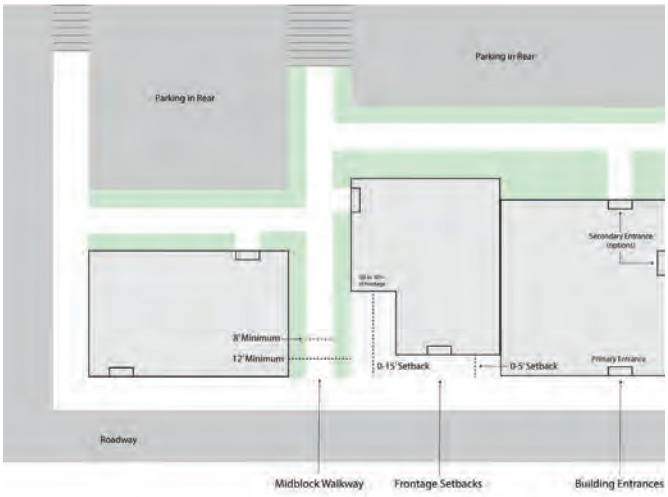
d. Loading docks, service areas, and drive-throughs shall be located on the side or rear of the building facade, and shall be screened from streets and adjacent properties through architectural design and landscaping where feasible.

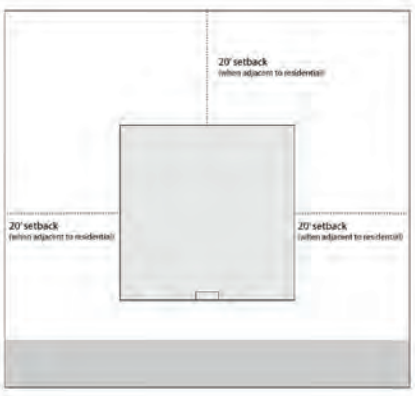
I. Maximum building height: Fifty feet (50').

a. Any new development shall provide a midblock walkway if a midblock walkway on the subject property has been identified in a plan adopted by the City. Alternate alignments may be considered subject to Planning Commission approval, provided they maintain equivalent connectivity and public access.

b. Midblock walkways shall be a minimum of twelve feet (12') in width and include a minimum eight foot (8') wide unobstructed path.

c. Midblock walkways may be incorporated into a building, provided they remain publicly accessible. A sign shall be posted indicating that the public may use the walkway.





10.6B.7 Off Street Parking and Loading

A. Parking Requirements:

Places of public assembly	1 space for each 8 seats
Medical Offices and dental clinics	1 space for each professional or paraprofessional practitioner
Customer service establishments	1 space for each 500 square feet of gross leasable area
Restaurant or bar	1 space for every 250 square feet of gross leasable area
Motel, hotel, or other tourist accommodation	1 space for each bedroom or unit
Residential	1 space for each dwelling unit

a. The building inspector shall determine the classification of a permitted use in cases where there is a question and apply a reasonable parking requirement.

B. Parking Requirements: Loading Requirements: One usable off-street loading space of not less than two hundred (200) square feet shall be provided for each ten thousand (10,000) square feet of floor area. This space shall be provided in addition to off street parking requirements.

C. Location: All off-street parking shall be located at the rear of buildings and accessed from side streets or shared driveways wherever feasible. Downtown businesses are encouraged to share parking areas as described below.

D. Surface Materials: All off-street parking areas shall be paved with asphalt or concrete surfaces.

E. Pedestrian Access: Off-street parking areas shall include a safe, direct, and accessible pedestrian connection to building entrances and adjacent public sidewalks where feasible.

F. Shared Parking: Parking requirements may be fulfilled through shared off-street parking agreements with adjacent or nearby properties, or between different uses within the same property.

a. Shared parking spaces must be located within six hundred feet (600') of participating uses. Distance shall be measured from the closest public entrance of each building to the shared parking area.

b. A written shared parking agreement, recorded with the city, is required between participating property owners. The agreement shall specify the number and location of spaces to be shared and the applicable reduction factor being applied.

c. Reduction Factors: Where two properties with complementary uses share parking, parking requirements may be reduced as follows (applied to each property's parking requirement):

i. Residential and retail: 10% reduction

ii. Residential and office: 15% reduction

iii. Retail and office: 10% reduction

iv. Restaurant and office: 5% reduction

v. Additional reductions may be approved for other use pairings not listed subject to city approval.

10.6B.8 Fences, Walls and Retaining Walls

A. Fences and walls located along street frontage shall not exceed four feet (4') in height and shall be of decorative design.

B. Fences, walls and retaining walls not exceeding ten feet (10') in height may be erected at the rear or side of a lot to screen service areas, loading areas, or parking areas, or to buffer adjacent residential lots.

C. Where parking lots, courtyards, or pedestrian areas abut one another, fences or walls shall provide a pedestrian connection at least six feet (6') in width to allow shared access, unless determined infeasible by the planning commission.

D. Barbed wire, sharp pointed metal fences and electrically charged fences shall not be permitted.

E. Fences shall be maintained in a good state of repair.

F. Open mesh fences of any height may be erected on zone lots containing schools, public parks and playgrounds.

G. The height of fences under this section shall include combinations of walls and fences and shall be measured from the high side of adjoining properties

10.6B.9 Supplemental Design Guidelines

Applicants shall review the Downtown Design Guidelines contained in the Blanding Downtown Plan and are encouraged to adhere to them where feasible. In reviewing development proposals in the Downtown District, the Planning Commission and City staff shall consider the Downtown Design Guidelines to promote consistency within the desired downtown character.

10.11 Off Street Parking and Loading

10.11.1 General Requirements

C. Same Lot And Ownership: Off street parking and loading facilities shall be provided on the same zone lot and under the same ownership as the permitted use for which the parking is required, unless otherwise provided under a shared parking agreement in accordance with Section 10-6B-7.

10.11.1 General Requirements

10.12.55 D Downtown District

A. On Premises Signs: On premises signs are based on the following formula: One square foot of sign for each linear foot of business frontage up to a maximum of fifty (50) square feet. Properties having five hundred (500) linear feet or more of business frontage shall be allowed fifty (50) square feet of additional signage.

1. Projecting signs are permitted as on-premises signs and shall not exceed twelve (12) square feet per sign, may project no more than four feet (4') from the building facade, and shall maintain a minimum clearance of eight feet (8') above the sidewalk.

B. Portable Signs: Portable sign requirements:

1. Signs shall only be placed in front of the business.
2. Maximum area of sign face shall not exceed eight (8) square feet per side.
3. Signs shall not interfere with public access, such as: sidewalks, roads, driveways, traffic, etc.
4. Signs shall only be allowed during business operation. When closed, signs shall be taken down and stored on the business property.
5. All signs must meet all general sign requirements (section 10-12-2 of this chapter).

C. Off Premises Signs: Off premises signs are prohibited within the D Downtown District.

D. Maximum Height: The maximum height for any sign shall not exceed fifteen feet (15').

10.14 Landscaping

10.14.55 D Downtown District

All area within a zone not required for buildings, off-street parking, or accessory uses shall be landscaped. Within the D downtown district, required landscaping may be substituted by pedestrian-oriented spaces such as outdoor dining, seating areas, plazas, or courtyards.

Appendix

B Downtown District Design Guidelines

This guide supplements the Blanding Downtown District Zoning Code. These guidelines are intended to inform and shape development within the Downtown District by outlining best practices and desired design outcomes. While not regulatory standards, applicants are expected to apply these guidelines to the extent feasible and demonstrate how their projects align with the Downtown District's goals.

Site Planning

Good site planning begins with a clear understanding of the property — its size, shape, surroundings, and relationship to the street and neighboring uses. Site design should balance the functional needs of businesses with the community's goals for safety, connectivity, and visual character.

BUILDING ORIENTATION AND ENTRANCES. Buildings should face and frame the public street, creating usable, safe, and attractive pedestrian spaces. Primary entrances must be clearly visible and welcoming from the sidewalk and may be highlighted with canopies, recessed entries, planters, seating, distinctive paving, or lighting.

PRESERVATION OF EXISTING FEATURES. Site development should minimize disruption to distinctive natural and cultural features such as mature trees, natural drainageways, rock outcrops, and historic or agricultural structures. When possible, these features should be incorporated into site design rather than removing or obscuring them.

OPEN SPACE. Provide open space that preserves notable site features and contributes to downtown's small-town character. Where possible, connect open spaces across property lines to form continuous networks. Open spaces should remain primarily natural and unpaved and may include shaded seating/picnic areas, native plantings, bioretention areas, or naturalistic water features.

CORNER BUILDINGS. Corner locations offer opportunities to create dynamic focal points within the downtown streetscape. Architectural and site features such as distinctive detailing, enhanced lighting, landscaping, or signage should emphasize the prominence of the corner and relate visually to the building design. Entrances may face the primary street or be placed at the corner.

Circulation Planning

Downtown development should promote safe, efficient, and user-friendly circulation for all modes of travel. Site layouts should limit unnecessary driveways and curb cuts, provide clear routes for vehicles and pedestrians, and encourage shared access between neighboring properties.

CURB CUTS AND ACCESS. Minimize driveway access on major roads to reduce conflicts between vehicles and pedestrians. Where feasible, combine or share access points between adjacent commercial properties.

CONNECTIONS BETWEEN PROPERTIES. Provide vehicular and pedestrian connections between adjoining parcels and parking lots to reduce short car trips on Main/Center Streets and improve walkability. Design these links for low speeds, good visibility, and direct pedestrian routes, and anticipate future connections to undeveloped parcels.

DRIVE-THROUGHS. Drive-throughs are discouraged. Where absolutely necessary, place lanes at the rear of the building, keep them separate from primary pedestrian routes, and design them to prevent queuing into parking aisles or sidewalks.

PEDESTRIAN AND BICYCLE CIRCULATION. Provide clear, direct internal paths that connect entrances, parking areas, sidewalks, and the midblock walkway network. Align walkways with building entrances or other focal points to aid wayfinding.

Parking Areas

Parking lots should be designed to complement adjacent buildings without visually dominating the downtown area. The total amount of visible pavement should be minimized through thoughtful layout, shared parking arrangements, and the use of landscaping to break up large areas. Parking lots should feel safe and welcoming, with clear pedestrian walkways, shade, and adequate lighting.

PLACEMENT. Locate parking primarily to the side or rear of buildings to maintain active street frontages. Where lots adjoin residential, schools, churches, or similar uses, soften views with fencing and landscaping. Encourage shared parking to reduce total paved area and improve efficiency.

PEDESTRIAN ACCESS. Provide clearly defined pedestrian routes within and between lots that connect directly to building entrances, sidewalks, and midblock walkways.

LANDSCAPING. Break up large paved areas with landscaped islands, trees, or low plantings to reduce heat and glare and improve comfort. Use hardy, drought-tolerant species suited to Blanding's climate.

DEAD END CIRCULATION. Parking lots should have at least two points of access where possible to avoid dead-end layouts and reduce congestion. Dead-end parking lots are discouraged and, when unavoidable, should include an area that allows vehicles to turn around safely.

INFILL DEVELOPMENT. Smaller commercial buildings within existing parking lots are encouraged as a way to strengthen the street edge and reduce the scale of large lots. These infill buildings can create a more continuous and engaging frontage, provide new opportunities for small businesses, and make better use of underutilized land.

MATERIALS. Parking lots should be constructed with asphalt or concrete and maintain clear striping. Avoid gravel surfaces.

Pedestrian Spaces

Downtown development should create inviting outdoor spaces that encourage people to walk, linger, and interact. Pedestrian spaces can take many forms such as outdoor dining areas, small plazas, shaded seating, landscaped courtyards, or recessed entries.

OUTDOOR SPACES. Outdoor pedestrian-oriented spaces such as plazas, courtyards, outdoor dining areas, or small seating areas are encouraged. Up to 30% of a building's frontage may be recessed up to 15 feet to provide these pedestrian spaces without disrupting the overall street alignment. Spaces should include amenities such as benches, shade structures, planters, or decorative lighting to enhance comfort and visual interest.

WALKWAYS. Sidewalks and midblock walkways should be constructed to provide safe, convenient pedestrian movement. Lighting and other amenities abutting walkways should be at human scale. Crosswalks should be provided where these walkways intersect with driveways. Traffic-calming measures such as curb extensions, raised crossings, or pedestrian refuge islands are encouraged where feasible.

LIGHTING. Pedestrian areas should be well lit to ensure safety and comfort during evening hours. Use warm lighting and conceal or shield sources to reduce glare and light spill onto neighboring properties.

LANDSCAPING AND AMENITIES. Pedestrian spaces should include landscaping that provides shade, color, and year-round interest. Trees, planters, and flower beds can help soften the built environment and define pedestrian spaces. Seating, public art, and decorative elements should be incorporated where appropriate.

Architectural Design

Building design should contribute to a cohesive, attractive streetscape. Well-designed architecture enhances the pedestrian experience, reinforces the rhythm of the street, and reflects the downtown character.

BUILDING CHARACTER. Building design should respect the established rhythm of the street (narrow frontages, simple forms) while complementing nearby buildings. Contemporary architecture is welcome when it reflects these same principles of simplicity, high-quality design, and compatibility with adjacent buildings.

MATERIALS. Buildings should use durable, high-quality materials that age well and are appropriate to Blanding's climate. Materials should convey a sense of permanence and craftsmanship and complement surrounding properties. Highly reflective or artificial finishes should be avoided.

COLOR. Colors should be muted and low-reflectance, drawing from regional tones such as earth, clay, and sage. Brighter colors may be used sparingly for accents on doors, awnings, or signage. Fluorescent, metallic, or overly glossy colors should be avoided as primary façade finishes.

FACADE TRANSPARENCY AND SCALE. Ground-floor frontages should include windows for active uses. Designed at pedestrian scale. As guidance, aim for approximately 50–70% transparency between 2 ft and 10 ft above sidewalk grade in the Core blocks. Use clear, non-reflective glass (avoid dark tints and mirror finishes). Upper floors should feature vertically proportioned windows arranged in a consistent rhythm.

ENTRANCES. Entrances should be visible from the sidewalk and may be highlighted with awnings, canopies, recessed doors, lighting, and quality hardware.

BLANK WALLS. Avoid uninterrupted blank walls longer than 50 ft on any public-facing frontage. Where unavoidable, mitigate with articulations, material changes, murals, or landscaping.

SIGNAGE. Signs should be incorporated into building design where feasible. Illuminated or flashing signs should be avoided on primary frontage.